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Teen And Up Audiences

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Post-Canon, Hurt/Comfort, Friendship/Love, POV Catra (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Adora (She-Ra) is a Dork, wholesome lesbians, Bow (She-Ra) in Over His Head, Lesbians in Space, Entrapta Being Entrapta (She-Ra), Best Friends Squad

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A Light in the Dark

by 4theHonourofGräysküll (AVAwolfpack), But_Its_For_Science (DakianDelomast), DakianDelomast

Summary

Demons don't die easy. Our darkness follows us long after the night has passed. I want to live in the light, but it feels so far away. In the quiet of space, I hope we find peace and love. And I hope you and your friends can forgive me, some day. - Catra

The Best Friends Squad finds themselves on their next adventure after the Heart and the defeat of Horde Prime. They know that the universe needs to heal. But what can they do for each other? Many unspoken apologies linger between them. Catra finds herself square in the middle of them. Her actions as a Force Captain of the Horde may have been forgiven, but not in her mind. Not yet.

___

"You're still Adora. Same jacket, same ponytail, same canvas pants. You're the woman I remember. But then you're She-Ra. You can just be another person. You became a princess but you…" You didn't have to see, to do the things that I did. "Hey, hey, hey." Your fingers cup the sides of my head, thumbs on my cheeks. You gingerly rest your forehead against mine. "She-Ra has nothing to do with what changed." I feel you take a deep breath that wafts against my face. "But a lot did. Can I… tell you about it?"

Notes

And we're off! Catra was first on deck for her novella since she was the primer for this whole project. Her story was a fun exploration of not just making the choice to become a better person, but following through. Her journey and trauma have

given her a special set of talents that no one in the BFS will have. She will find a way to bring the love into her life that she fought so hard to get back.

We decided to make this series a First/Second person perspective and it has really driven the intimacy and the complications that Catra has with her relationship with Adora and She-Ra. We'll watch their complexity and trials unfold and in the end, maybe Catra can reconcile the two again.

Echoes

My ear hurts. I shift my head on the pillow and rattle the hard cot under me, freeing it from confinement. It twitches once, twice, flitting against the rock of the pillow. I settle back in, and an arm slides over my waist, gliding against the delicate fur there. It reaches up, locks over my chest, and I am dragged into the warmth behind me.

My breath hitches.

A face nuzzles into the back of my head, burrowing into the fur. I hear something. Drown in the soporific murmurs is my name.

"Catra."

I feel your body press closer against me; the arm cinches down tighter. My tail threads between your legs. You surround me. The heat of your slumbering breaths radiate down my neck, lacing delicate fingers of vapor over my collarbone.

You nuzzle deeper into my hair. Fingers meander through my fur. I want to settle. I want to relax into the embrace. Every muscle is taut. Everything is starting to ache. Threads tear as my claws clench down on the hard mattress. I try to breathe. Perfuma's words find me. *Deep in. Hold. Deep out. Hold. Let the positive energy fill you, and push out the negative.*

My heart slows. I push back into your embrace.

Your lips touch the back of my neck.

I see all, Little Sister.

No.

I clench and push away, wrestling the arm off me. I squirm, crawl, push; the arm holds for a moment, dragging me back into the green ooze and pain. I feel it drawing me in. I crawl harder.

My body pulls against the currents. The tide rushes in. Not the Velvet Glove. The apathetic clones, the sterility of a space station with a hint of sweet amniotic fluid that persists everywhere. No.

The hand lets go. I pounce away from the cot.

"Catra?" The confused voice calls from the darkness, dimly illuminated by the blue glow of the persistent light of Darla. You lazily push up on your arm. The heart, the First Ones' brand of your selflessness shimmers on your chest over your gray tank top. Melog chirrs in response to the disturbance, raising their head as well.

"It's okay Adora. I just need to use the bathroom." A lie. My chest feels ready to collapse and explode like a supernova. Another vision of Prime's light, the death of an entire system, watched from the relative safety of a window. The picturesque destruction of not just a world but billions of people.

They should have just obeyed.

"Okay." Your voice is suspicious, but it doesn't argue. I sit there. Melog's blue eyes close, and they curl back up at the foot of the bed.

Breathe in.

Breathe out.

Your peaceful slumbering breaths basks the room in a calming resonance. My hand hurts, my arm hurts, my neck hurts. I unclench my hand and relax my arm. The nails pull free of skin and I inspect my claws. They are coated in blood painted black in the blue light. I unwind my body and stand.

I approach the door and thumb on the pad with a delicate press, only cracking the sliding door. I wait. The cool, sterile air of the ship brushes by my nose. No one is wandering around out there. I slip through the door, and debate on closing it. I peer

back into the room. You are sprawled chest down on the cot, with the light playing on your profile.

Melog looks at me again. “Stay. Just, right now. Stay. Please.”

There is a reluctance in their body. A soft meow of a question.

“Yes, I’ll be back.”

I slip through, naked feet padding on the cool metal plates.

Why does Entrapta let Darla keep this ship so frigid?

I make my way to the cockpit, and repeat the same as before. I thumb gently on the pad, and it opens the door a crack. Another brief inspection confirms no one is going to be in there.

The edge of the canopy calls to me. With a few quick steps I sit back on it, watching the endless space slip by. Stars. Quiet.

Prime.

I squeeze my eyes shut. He isn’t real. He isn’t here anymore. He isn’t anywhere. You saw to that. He isn’t anywhere, but—

I touch the back of my neck, and inspect the prints of blood on my fingers.

“You seem to be injured.”

I yelp and crash my head against the sloped glass canopy. The knock scatters a couple stars across my vision. I kick my legs over the console and hold my head.

“You seem—more injured.”

“Yes, very astute, Entrapta.” She must have snuck through the vents. My teeth set in my mouth with a clench.

“I can get that patched up!” A menagerie of devices and equipment entangled in her tentacles of hair unfurl from behind

her like an octopus with surgical intentions.

"No that's okay!" I hold up a hand and push myself against the glass behind.

"Ohhh, that kind of injury, too." Her purple pigtails fold back behind her as she forms a couch with them.

"What?" Her positivity is already setting my rattled nerves back on edge.

She folds her gloved hands under her chin and visibly dissects me. "Well you see, there's a spike in your adrenaline and cortisol which is binding with your neuroreceptors and keeping your thalamus from completing it's neuroregulation and shutting down the higher functioning cortexes."

"Excuse me?" I stretch my sleep-shorts back down my leg where they are riding up on me, smoothing the elastic fabric.

She sighs. "You're upset and you can't sleep good." She mimes the two hands on the side of her head to emphasize her point.

"Yeah, thanks genius."

"I can help! Hey, Darla! Can yo—"

"No! Stop. Nothing else. Just leave me alone right now. I'll be okay." I hold my hand out for emphasis. My claws are matte in the light of Darla's cockpit.

Entrapta stands there, her ruby eyes puzzling at me, glancing up and down. Her gaze fixates on my claws. My blood. I suddenly feel very naked. She folds her legs, one over the other, and her heavy boots scrape against the reinforced fabric of her overalls. "Can I please do something to help?"

I stop myself from another bark, quenching a hot steel rod of frustration in my throat. Her eyes, that look. She just wants to…

I take a pause. I bite back the anger. “I don’t know.”

“Can I stay up here with you then? I think sometimes it’s good to sit with someone. Even if you don’t say anything.” She tilts her head to the side and moves cautiously towards me a little.

“I think I’d like that.” I look down at my claws and resist the urge to brush them against my shorts.

She doesn’t move. She sits, expectant. The pause lingers and her eyes shift left and right.

I curl my tail around me and grasp it with both of my hands wringing at the stiffened hairs. Just the quiet of the ship fills the empty void between us. The expected conversation sits just beyond our reach.

She sits up with a leap, and dangles from her pigtails. I yelp and almost hit my head on the canopy again.

“I’m gonna go work on Darla!” Entrapta’s spider-like hair takes her over to the main console and she sits down. She pulls the emotionless buglike visage of her mask over her face and hunches over the keys to tap away at them.

I take a deep breath, releasing the anxiety withheld in my chest. Entrapta’s focus is lost in the ship’s diagrams. Different subsystems flash by, glinting off the mask. She hunches over the computer, the dark purple of her mechanic’s suit contrasts with the white of her persistent white tank top. With the mask down she looks more like a—

I stop my thoughts. A person. She looks like a person. My fingers are aching again. I relax them and hear the nails come free of the metal they are embedded in. I guess it’s time to go back to bed.

Darla’s orb snaps into a purple light that fills the room as she breaks the silence. “Administrator access required.”

“Whaaat? Darla, I thought we were past this.” Entrapta lifts her mask, pleading with Darla.

My ear flicks in irritation at the sudden noise. “What’s going on?”

Entrapta turns with hurt obvious in her eyes. “Darla and I have been working through her systems and I’ve noticed that there are gaps in her core functions. I have been trying to debug why, but…” Entrapta keys the pad again without looking back to it.

“Administrator access required.”

“Well,” I swing my legs where they dangle on the console, “we have one administrator on this ship.”

“We have to go wake up Adora!” Entrapta lifts again on the stilts made of her hair and lunges to the vent. I leap at her and grasp the length of her hair and drag her down. Wrenching her back. She lands on top of me.

“Why did you do that?” She looks at me puzzled, sitting on top of my chest.

I wrestle myself out from under her and kneel, fixing my top. “Let’s let Adora sleep for *once* .”

Entrapta looks back to the vent, and then back to me. “But… Darla.”

“Why don’t you show me what you’ve been working on until everyone gets up?”

“Okay!” She wraps me in a tendril of hair, and drags me over to the console with her.

I guess I didn’t need to sleep, after all.

“Why again are we stopping?” Bow’s question is punctuated by a wide yawn. His dark eyes scan at his feet.

“Catra and I stayed up all night with Darla! We were blocked with the firewall, but with some *clever* diagnostics we know that the missing parts are modules even if we don’t know *what* they are.” Entrapta stands next to the purple orb of Darla’s visage at the front of the cockpit. The stars stand still behind her, and a pair of planets frame the nose of the ship. One a pale green mass of clouds, the other a barren, rocky orb with a light blue hue on the surface.

“So you had Darla reroute us to... This.” Bow adjusts his knit sweater, pulling it away from his neck.. The heart in the middle of it scintillates with some magic imbuement.

Glimmer sits close, not quite touching. Her neck is craned upward to look at him. She relaxes, returning to a somewhat resigned pose. Her eyes are tired. She catches my stare and perks up again, pulling her long cloak around her. She almost disappears in starlight.

Micah’s eyes shift from me, to Bow and Glimmer. His wrinkled brow furrows in suspicion. He opens his mouth to say something, but seems to think better of it. Nothing is amiss, clearly.

I grin and peer up at your soft, tapered jawline set in consideration. “If it’s locked behind an administrator key, it could be good Bow. Might be worth the stop.” Your voice thrums against my shoulder. You spare a glance at me and I relax, nestling into your red jacket with my cheek. The lack of sleep starts to catch up with me. I settle in my position on your lap at the commander’s chair with my foot twitching as it tapers off the side. Your dopey smile glows down on me. You big idiot.

“Darla, can you give us any clue what’s missing from your systems?” Micah’s haggard voice barely cuts through my focus on you.

Darla dims, and her grid of lines tighten and relax. Maybe that's her version of a blink? "Administrator access required."

The room turns to us. You break our gaze and look back at them staring blankly.

I shift my body into yours. "Uh, administrator?"

You sit up in a startle. "Oh! Right. Darla, what subsystems are you missing?"

Darla's luminescence brightens and a black dot appears in the middle of her orb, tracking you. "Administrator Adora recognized. I cannot extrapolate based on information I do not have. I know my systems are only partially functional. And some of the First Ones tech I scanned on the nearby system could be used to reactivate some of my missing components."

What could have been taken since the wreck? Hordak's lab makes a little more sense in this context, though. I settle my head against your shoulder, arms crossed, and tail flicking between your legs.

"Imagine what she could do with more tech!" Entrapta's elation is, as always, intoxicating.

"Supposing we can fix her with whatever is down there, do we know anything about these planets?" Glimmer can't hide the torpor in her voice. Her hand emerges from her cloak again as she teases at her disheveled purple hair. It sets off a cascade of glittering light.

Darla's glowing orb flickers as she replies, "My scans show active movement on the surface of Kalim. I believe it may be rampant First Ones bots."

"Then let's move on." Micah shifts on his feet and nervously straightens a wrinkle on his royal purple robe. His wizened face bears the most worry out of all of us.

"I agree. I think we should keep on to the Star Siblings. It's not worth a risk." Bow nods in affirmation.

"But—" Entrapta's face is crestfallen. Her interlaced fingers plead at everyone wordlessly.

There's a jostle under me disturbing my sneaking slumber. "I have an idea. Darla, do you have any records of how you and Mara found Etheria?" Your voice is always so soothing.

I close my eyes and lean into you, settling back in. You seem to be the only one getting good rest on this trip so far.

"I only have fractures of our logs. It seems the crash corrupted a significant portion of my nonvolatile memory. However, by extrapolating the time gaps from timestamp fragments found in my databanks, I can deduce that several thousand candidates were pursued in the search of magic."

My eyes snap open. "How did you manage to move that fast? It's taken us months to just reach one system."

"I do not know the answer to this inquiry."

"Maybe she has a miniaturized portal drive!" As she speaks, Entrapta rises on a twisting pillar of her hair.

You smile down at me. "I think it's worth a look."

Your gaze draws out a sigh from me that I am barely aware of. Sheepishly, I grin back at you. I hear Melog purring behind us, rumbling the chair. Until I realize that it's me. I don't care. I feel your fingers scratch delicately against the back of my scalp. I lean back into them.

"Let's do it." Glimmer drops a fist into her open palm for emphasis.

"I don't like going in there on just a gamble, Baby Girl." Micah tugs at his beard in concern.

“Yeah, well, last I checked Queen and She-Ra outrank you, Dad,” Glimmer says lightly, but still serious.

He holds up his hands, resigned.

“So what’s the plan? Melog can hide us, but that’s a lot of bots even for them.” I absently scratch at my collarbone under my button-up shirt.

“Darla, pull up a heat map on the surface of Kalim.” Bow walks into the middle of the room where a surface map with hills, ridges, and rocks overlays the empty space. On it, dots of light teem. He swipes a hand through the air, a thoughtful finger cupped around his chin. He stops at a small hill that is cascading with the ants of the light. “First Ones bots tend to collect around the strong sources of their tech. I think that might be our best bet.”

“Okay great.” I sling my legs off you and stand up. I feel your hand linger on my hip and slip away. “So how do we go in? Entrapta, can you set up a disabling signal from Darla?”

She looks down at me from atop her pillar and shrugs.

“All right, Micah, Glimmer, what about a spell from the air that can hit the spot with a blizzard and freeze the bots in-place?” I turn to them, and see more blankness. “Doesn’t anyone have an idea here?” Melog curls around my feet and rubs a shoulder against the back of my thigh.

You smile. “How about we imp—”

“If you say improvise I’m throwing you out of the airlock.”

“We… come up with a flexible plan that can be adjusted on the fly?” Your smirk. I forget my anger.

But I still manage a glare.

The airlock door opens. I grab tight onto your hand. With my other I clench at the support webbing attached to the interior of the ship.

"Just so we're clear, I don't like this plan." I mutter into the mic of the space suit.

"You're the one that said we needed one." The reflection of the small craggy planet glints off the dome of your helmet.

"Making a stupid plan doesn't count!"

"C'mon, Catra. I've done worse."

My hand flexes. I tug you a little closer. "I tried to stop you from that, too."

You turn and thread an arm back around me. There is a *clonk* of our helmets clashing together. "Then we know this one is going to work."

My fangs clench around my lip. I nod. "I don't want to land and just dump you down there with an army of bots. Even She-Ra needs backup."

You push gently away from me. I release my grip on you.

"You thought I was landing?" You wear an impish smile. You step back, the oblivion of a dead planet is your backdrop.

"What're you—?"

"Watch *this* !" You step off.

"Wait!"

You fall away. I rush to the end of the airlock. The surface of the blue-gray field is clustered in small boulders, ones that swarm and roil. They slide along the rocks, crests, and valleys. More bots than I ever knew were possible. I catch sight of your diminishing

figure as it shrinks into nothing, headed straight for an extinct volcano.

"Adora!" I cry into the mic.

The speakers crackle. "*For the honor OF GRAYSKULL!"*

Light. A nova ignites in front of me, far below. Every color, even those unseen, explode away from the point. As soon as they are thrown away, the prismatic incandescence collapses back on the source. I see a small, finite mote of white-gold light that streaks to the ground like a falling star.

It disappears into the side of the volcano. At first there is nothing. Then everything. A shock wave of raw radiance tears down the side of the mountain into the surrounding valleys and plains that hold the countless bots. Each is a tiny explosion as the tide of light catches up to them. I can't tell how far it travels, but it looks over a mile wide before I see a geyser of air erupt from the side of the mountain.

Bow's voice chirps in through the speaker on the suit. "What the heck was that?"

"Dumbass got us in, Bow. We're clear for a landing."

Friends

"There." Entrapta looks up from her pad. The air slows from a rushing cacophony into a thin whistle as the emergency isolation bulkheads lock down. There's a heavy *clank* as they finish sealing shut. The sound echoes across the empty hallway we're in now. Glimmer teleported us into the service corridor adjacent to the She-Ra sized hole in the main access hall.

Even the most utilitarian of through-ways demonstrate the First Ones' technology. The ceiling of the hall is a point high above. It's wide enough for four of us to walk abreast, but only just. The walls are traced with horizontal lines and circles resembling the circuit boards hidden in the panels of Darla. They don't glow with blue-green light though. They're the dimmest red.

"Thank Etheria." I sigh. "I don't remember the hole being part of the *plan* ."

You smirk—well, She-Ra does. Her glowing form radiates light from her white suit and gold accents. It overpowers the meager light in the hall. The warrior of a woman crosses her arms in front of her. "It's still a door if it gets us in."

Her arrogance should annoy me, but my retort dies as my eyes linger on her. Confidence, strength—She-Ra is raw intoxicating power. And you are still my idiot, somewhere in there. Maybe it's not so bad? I catch myself. I blink and look to the side, crossing my arms. "You're an idiot."

The others are huddled around Entrapta's computer, thankfully ignoring us. No one saw the stupid blush rise in my cheeks.

"Is there enough air for us to still breathe?" Bow peers around Entrapta's shoulder.

"Oh yes. There's plenty and the system has a regenerator. Though it seems to be offline. A lot of things are." She lifts her

helmet with a loud *pop* and tosses it aside, barely stopping from her work. A pigtail scratches at her chin while her fingers and hair stab away at the keyboard. Floor plans, circuit diagrams, and ducting diagrams are open on all sides of the screen and reflect off the transparent material on the chest of her suit.

The popping of helmet seals releasing serenades the dark room as we remove them. Bow, Glimmer, and Micah hover around Entrapta's terminal. The light glints off Bow's stupid ab window when he turns to set his helmet aside.

"Looks like power is down across the board. There's not much in reserve." Bow mimes Entrapta's gesture of focus. "We have to be careful what we turn on or use. We're going to need to get through the heavy bulkheads." He gestures to a door nearby us. It's as wide as the rest of the corridor. Three gemstones adorn the face, arranged in a triangle with the same stylized grooves carved like in the rest of the hall. They glow with the dim red light in accordance with the rest of our surroundings.

"On it!" Glimmer hooks her arms through Bow's and Micah's who stand closest to her.

"No more teleports!" I shout before I can stop myself. The room turns to me. "I'm just, I'd rather keep the rest of my lunch in. Please."

"I could try one of my unlocking spells." Micah's suit vaguely matches his tunic and pants from Etheria. It's bulkier than the rest of ours. A large crescent moon stylizes the middle of his chest. He twists his hand and a red glyph materializes in front of him. He pushes and it scatters ineffectually against the closed door. He shrugs at his daughter.

"Good try, Dad." She pats his arm.

"We could try something else. Maybe it's password locked?" She-Ra approaches the door. "Um, Eternia!" The rest of the crew sits silently looking at her. She stands alone, befuddled by a door.

“She-Ra?” Still silence. “Administrator access… uh… requested. No! Demanded.” The words die in empty echos.

“You’re hopeless.” I roll my eyes. When I see your shoulders slump, though, a new idea strikes. “We can do it the old fashioned way.” I flex my fingers and claws extend.

It’s enough to change your mood instantly. You grin at me mischievously . “Now you’re talking.”

“What’s that?” Micah’s question barely leaves his lips.

She pivots and materializes She-Ra’s sword in her hands. But she’s still slow on the draw, as always. I unfurl my claws, and attack the bulkhead. My nails dig deep into the steel and leave a ragged, white scar in the surface. I drag both hands down at my shoulder width, and then perpendicular to that, leaving a small portal. I give a solid kick and knock the heavy plate inside. I follow it with a curl and a pounce through the opening. I stop long enough to check behind me, seeing the point of She-Ra’s sword dragging in a circle adjacent to the hole I just leapt through.

A dim red emergency light emanates from two large crystals towering as tall as myself on either side of the room. No matter. I move up and attack the next door. I finish just as She-Ra clambers through her ragged portal in the door.

“Guys!” Bow calls from on the other side of bulkhead. “These are probably airlock doors! Maybe we shouldn’t be cutting through them!” His voice cracks.

I cut another clean white line through the steel with my claws. “What, Bow? I can’t hear you!”

Just as She-Ra reaches the door and plunges the sword into it, I am already through my entryway and pause to watch her efforts. “You’re too chunky Adora! She-Ra needs to cut back on the cake!”

“I think—” She huffs and I hear her through the opening I just leapt through. “It’s First Ones’ metal so it’s resistant to my sword.”

“Hah! Please. You’ve just always been slow!”

This room is identical to the last; another bulkhead probably for the exact purpose Bow mentioned. She-Ra is halfway through making her cut and I dash on all fours to the next doorway. I finish the next cut and kick the window out. I prepare to leap before I smell it. The air of the past two rooms had been stale collections of dust. This smells—open. As I am thinking through this, the belated clang of the falling metal shard I kicked in finally reaches my ears.

“Whoa.” You stand beside me, already shifted away from She-Ra.

I spare a glance to the side, relieved to see you in… your shape. I forgot that Entrapta styled your jacket into your space suit. Sometimes I can’t even picture you without that stupid jacket. I resist a quip and look into the darkness of the opening I made. “I can’t even see what’s in there.”

The rest of the crew arrive and take turns staring into the room beyond. We’re unable to make anything out in the void.

“Dad, give me a hand?” Glimmer walks to the left of my handiwork and gestures Micah over to the opposite. Glimmer draws a glyph in the air, five stylized stars in a ring. He nods, understanding her intent and adds his own flourishes onto the pattern with another large star in the middle. They gesture with their hands through the dark portal, and the glyph moves inside.

It blossoms into daylight in the room. The void opens up, but into an expanse that still seems larger than the spell can manage. I look deeper, and below are countless lines of ships in various states of disrepair. They are a silent procession of entombed hulks. No two are alike, but they all seem derived from the same family of craft that is Darla’s.

“Think they have some spare parts?” Glimmer says with a lopsided smile.

“What! Let me see!” Strands of hair shove the entire party aside, splitting us down the middle. Entrapta’s face pops into the window and she shrieks with joy. “She was right!” A manic cackle rattles us, and I resist the temptation to hug her.

“Let’s get down there,” you say.

As soon as she touches the ground after the descent on Bow’s rope-arrow, Entrapta dashes to the nearby panel, opens it, and starts unraveling the wires with her snakes of hair. I leave her to it and join the others.

“They just go on forever,” Bow says.

“They had enough people to fly all of these?” The hope in your tone sends a small pang through me.

“I don’t know.” Glimmer walks forward and places a hand on the underside of one of the ships. It looks just like Darla, but only at a glance. Darla’s sleek and angular form has little to no clutter on it. These ships have ragged panels, or added accoutrements in pods or antennae. Every one of them is unique.

“They’re all personalized from the looks of it.” I drag a claw over one of the plates. Like Darla it resists more than the other steel of the First Ones, barely making a scratch.

“What did they need all of these for?” Micah follows the others. He gestures in the air with his fingers, forming a smaller glyph. He pushes it down to the ground and a blue pulse erupts in all directions. “I don’t sense any—”

Entrapta’s wail cuts him off.

My tail stiffens behind me and my ears leap up on top of my head. I sprint towards the noise to find her collapsed in front of

her terminal.

"What is it?" Micah is first on the draw with his concern.

"They're dead!" Her shoulders are slumped, and her face is turned away from us. Her body shakes up and down. I hear the tears, even though I can't see them.

"Who's dead?" Glimmer takes a step closer, while the rest of us hesitate. I feel a mix of worry and fear.

"I promised her that I'd find someone. She'd be less lonely."

I turn to you and whisper close enough that our conversation is held privately. "What did she promise you?"

"Me? Nothing!" I wince at your volume. Why couldn't you ever whisper?

Entrapta's body shudders. If she heard you, she makes no indication.

Bow holds a hand out and moves in to console her. "Entrapta, the First Ones died out a long time ago." He looks up, realizing what he said. Your face reveals a little pain, but she waves him off. He only speaks the truth. "I don't think it's surprising that they're all gone."

"Not them!" Her eyes burn with tears of anger. Her expression is hot, disarming. "The ships!" She flips the display around and it shows row upon row of gray dots. There's no tone, no light. Everything sprawls in a featureless mesh.

"Can't we just fire up the generator and reactivate them?" Bow's words and tone are careful, but it incenses Entrapta more.

"You don't understand. The ships are all random memory access! They can't hold all of their data in storage. If they power down completely, they lose the consciousness state. They're dead."

You are the bravest, walking over to Entrapta to squat next to her. "I'm sure there's something you can work out with Darla to get a couple of them back. They can help us rebuild the systems she is— *oof* !"

A *whack* of hair sends you sprawling onto your backside. "You don't *understand* ." Entrapta runs into the rows of ships and disappears in their silent shadows. We all exchange glances in her absence.

I cut the silence first. "What in the Heart was that?"

"I don't know. Micah, come with me. Let's go find her. Bow, Glimmer, Catra, go see what you can figure out on her workstation." Your words are quick and authoritative. I feel my tail curl. With a startle I straighten it back.

The three of us nod. Bow picks up her station and starts to scan through the screen. He taps one of the dots, and it shows a ship with First Ones' writing of some data either in specification or cataloging. "They're all powered down like she said." He taps another ship and it is a slightly different shape, with small differences in the writing.

"I'd think she'd have a translator installed by now." Glimmer squints at the words.

"Are you kidding me, Sparkles? She taught herself the language on Beast Island. Why's she need a translator?" I cross my arms and tap a finger on the sleeve of my suit.

"Okay, fair." She glares at me, but it's toothless.

"We're not going to be able to tell what's missing on Darla if they're all different though." Bow scratches his chin.

"Maybe we look for what's the same?" Glimmer cozies in closer to Bow. She rests a hand on his forearm and moves in alongside him.

“That could work!” He smiles down at her. His face darkens a little when he sees my noncommittal expression. He glides by the awkwardness and reaches into his quiver. He hands us two arrows. Both look identical to his normal repertoire. “Use these!” He pushes a nondescript button on the side and the head of the arrow turns into a small radar dish. He hands each of them to us and then pulls out his datapad. On it, he retrieves a schematic of Darla. “Scan all the ships you can find. I’ll keep a log of what their layouts are, and the most common features will keep showing up. After we have enough, I’ll compare the standard set of features on a ship against Darla and we’ll figure out what she needs!”

He catches my skepticism as I look between him and the scanner.

“What? Does it not make sense?”

“Oh, it makes sense. But why do they always have to be arrows?”

Glimmer stifles a giggle next to me.

I hold the arrow scanner up to the craft in front of me. This one has pods underneath the chin that look like some form of weapon. They remind me a little of Horde Prime’s laser cannons on his small ships. I press the button and the small device whirs, and then chirps when completed. I walk to the next one; this has two sets of pylons on the side, instead of the single pair that Darla has.

I catch Glimmer out of my periphery. She’s looking at me. “Hey, Catra?”

“Yeah?”

“Can I—” Her pregnant pause fills the emptiness around us. “Can we talk for a second?”

“What’s on your mind?”

"Bow and I—"

"Wait." I stop and set a hand on my hip. "I am *not* going to talk about whatever you two get up to alone."

She holds both hands out defensively. "No, not that! I'm just having trouble with him."

"I don't know what you're dancing around here, Sparkles. I'm not exactly an *expert* when my only reference is Adora and we—"

"He wants to know what happened on the Velvet Glove." Her shimmering eyes are pained. "He wants to know what *he* … did."

"Oh." I drop my hand down from my hip. The other reaches across me, clenching at my bicep. Bow's scanner arrow dangles dormant in my hand.

"Yeah. It's making it hard to have conversations with him sometimes. Have you talked about it with Adora?"

I reach up and touch the back of my neck, feeling at the scabs. "Not really."

"Why not?" She steps closer to me.

"It's hard to explain. Hard to make sense of it, you know?"

"I do." She sinks to her knees and sits back on her heels. "Can we talk?"

"Can't you wait to talk with Perfuma about this? She's better at this stuff."

"I have, and she said I should talk with you. She said you're hurting, too. Please, Catra." Her face is tired, wounded. I wonder what mine looks like right now.

I feel trapped and a little betrayed, but I don't see another option. I sit back on my heels as well. Suddenly, I really want

Melog here, but they're still on the ship keeping Darla cloaked. I guess I can handle this on my own. "Do you... want to sit back to back again?"

She smiles at me. "I'd be okay with that."

We turn and rest our backs against one another. This time, without the barrier of the cell between us, her warmth—her strength presses against mine. I curl my tail around her waist and rest it on her lap.

I take a breath, unsure of what to say. Maybe just something to start? "So what's he asking you about?"

She absently runs a hand along my tail, smoothing out the fur. "He wants to know if I was hurt there. If Horde Prime did anything to me."

"Like he did to me?"

"I don't think he means it like that."

My tail twitches in her hands straining a little from the resistance. "It's all right."

"I'm trying to explain it to him, but there's something missing."

"Like what?" I push back against her and feel a gentle pressure back.

"Catra—I… can I tell you something?"

"That's why we're sitting like this." I reach down next to me and drag a claw across the floor, silently pulling a curl of metal up.

I hear an uncomfortable laugh behind me. "This isn't the easiest thing to talk about."

"Is any of this?" I flick the curl of metal aside with a *ping* and rest my hands on my knees.

"It's about... about what happened before Horde Prime got us."

"Oh." My tail flicks out of her hands reflexively. As if this will let me escape from the conversation. As if it were that easy.

"You saved my life, Catra. I'll always be grateful to you for that. You've made up for a lot of things since… But I still wound up on Horde Prime's ship—I lost my mother," she swallows, "because of you. I guess… I'm still trying to understand that."

My breath holds.

"She—when I got back to Bright Moon, my mother wasn't there. She was gone like she never existed. And everyone acted like it. I was just suddenly supposed to be queen, and everything would be okay. But it wasn't. It hasn't been. She's gone and I don't know if I'll ever be okay. She doesn't have a body, or a grave. She is just *gone* —lost in that Portal somewhere."

I bite my tongue and taste blood.

"I was so angry. I wanted to hurt everyone. I wanted to take her back. I wanted to hurt," she takes a measured pause, "you."

The word falls like a rock down an empty well, rattling as it plunges and landing with a resonating thud. Anger, defensiveness, they all rise in me. I feel my fingers flex and extend my claws.

"When I found out the Heart of Etheria was a weapon, I wanted to use it on everyone that hurt me. Bow and Adora tried to stop me, and I didn't… I didn't listen. And then Horde Prime came. It felt like my anger took me to him. I—We saw horrible things, Catra. I was the only person that could save Etheria, and he toyed with me, and my friends. He made me think that at any second it would be my fault if everyone was killed, or if he decided to eradicate another people. He wanted me to always know he had control." She pauses for a breath. "I feel as though I deserved it for what I did."

I swallow a contorted knot of feelings. "That's what they do."

"I think about that, too. I feel like I might understand a little better what you and Adora went through when you were kids."

I shake my head, my grip tightening on my knees. A faint crackle of electricity through my joints—the ghost of her power over me. "Shadow Weaver was never like that. Horde Prime was worse."

"I know." She sighs and some of the pressure leaves me as she leans forward. "That's what I think about, and I can't talk with anyone about it, because they don't really understand."

"Unless they lived it too?"

"Yeah."

Another silence lingers between us.

I take a deep breath. Courage. "It's not your fault what he did."

"But he—"

"No 'but's. He was a monster. He was the worst monster I have ever seen. And I wish I could have been more like you." My tail ventures back around into her lap, reconnecting us. Reaching out in a way I never quite could otherwise.

"What?" she says, half-laughing.

"I mean, I got trapped. It started with Shadow Weaver, and never ended." I raise a hand up. My fingers lace back towards my neck, claws still extended. I stop myself. I *have* to stop myself. Instead, I clutch at the side of my head. "It just got worse with Prime. I had to get you out of there because Adora would get trapped again, too. And I couldn't let that happen. But you idiots came back." A smile creeps onto my face. "And the first thing you did was grab one of his stupid sticks and beat his clones to death with it."

There's a loud bark of a laugh through her tears. I didn't know she was crying.

I am too. I wipe a tear away. "I should've thought of that." I take a shaky breath. "I don't know how you can tell Bow about it, Sparkles. But… I don't know… Maybe we can talk about it or whatever." I trail off on my last words.

I feel her hand envelope mine. Before I can move she has spun me around, and I am locked into an embrace with her. She buries her face into my spacesuit. She cries, and I join her. Quiet sobs in the desolate hangar. We stay like that for a while before Glimmer's pad chirps, startling the two of us.

"Hey, is the data connection good?"

"Yeah, Bow. We took a break to look inside one of the ships." Glimmer tries to disguise her tears.

"You okay?" His face squints in concern.

"Just a bunch of dust." I peer over the top of the screen to see his face, upside down.

"Well, all right. Adora and Micah just got back with Entrapta. She's—she seems fine now. She's working on the data from the scans. You sure you're okay, Glimmer?"

"I'm fine. We're almost done." Glimmer squirms in front of me but does her best to hide it from the screen.

"Okay, be careful. We still don't know if the bots can get in from the outside or not."

"We will. I'll take care of her, Arrow Boy." I wink at him.

"Okay, thanks Catra." He smiles.

"See you soon, hun."

Bow's posture stiffens, and his cheeks flush. "See… See you soon." The pad winks off.

A wanting expression lingers on Glimmer as she sets the pad down.

I branch through thoughts of what could be bothering her before the epiphany hits. "No I love you?"

"He's been a bit tense with my dad around, I guess." Her eyes fixate on our laps. "Catra." She looks up at me, irises glittering in the light above. "Thank you."

I squeeze her hand. "I'm trying. Adora's got this idea in her head that I'm supposed to be nice to everyone."

She smiles. "Well, it's working. I have things I need to make up for too. Let me know what I can do."

I pause, flexing my mouth to the side in thought. "I have an idea."

"What?"

"Don't teleport us back when we're done with the scanning. I don't think my stomach can take another. Can we just walk this time?"

Her smile broadens. "Deal."

I drag a claw over the top of the supply box I am sitting on. The fine tip digs a curl of steel up and away from the surface, leaving a gouge of bright, fresh metal behind. With my other hand, I twiddle with the button on my shirt at the top of my sternum. You and Bow dust with a pair of brooms across the way in the cargo bay of Darla. Out of the corner of my eye, I spy your glare at me. You huff and sweep a little too hard, kicking a puff of dust into the air. Subtly has never been your strong suit.

Bow coughs. “You all right?”

“Yeah, just *peachy* , Bow.” You grab the dustpan and set it on the floor kicking a small pile of detritus into it.

“Hey, the ship only has two brooms. I already finished moving the boxes.” I finish the line with my claw and start at the top again, drawing another one at an angle from the first.

“You moved *two* boxes, Catra.” You dump the contents of the dustbin into a nearby empty container that once held protein slaw.

“Well, the rest are too heavy.”

“You could just grab the—”

“So, I got a question for you guys.” Bow follows your action, dumping his pan into the bin, though more gently.

You turn your glare from me back to Bow. “Yeah, what’s up?”

I finish with the other line. And I draw a smaller one intersecting the two in the middle. Melog watches my work with curiosity from where they lay, head resting on their paws.

He sets the broom and pan aside on a nearby stack of crates. “Do you guys ever call each other anything other than, you know, your names?”

You furrow your brow and look between me and Bow. “No, why would I do that?”

“I mean, I call her idiot.” I look up to him.

You relax back into your smug, goofy grin. “Actually, I used to call Catra The Great Mouser of The Fright Zone.” You rest the broom against you and make a pair of mouse ears with your hands.

Melog mews at me and I scowl at them.

"That was *one* time."

"No." Bow holds his hands up. "Not… not like that. Guys, c'mon. I'm talking about how like Netossa and Spinnerella call each other 'Spinny' and 'Darling'."

"Yeah, what's up with that?" I draw a circular line, stopping short of connecting the ends together. "It's kind of gross if you ask me."

"It's not…" Bow covers his eyes. "Would you guys listen?"

"Why's it bother you what Spinnerella and Netossa call each other, Bow?" You balance the broom on its head, holding both hands on top of the handle to steady it.

A vein in Bow's forehead looks ready to pop. "It doesn't *bother* me. I… Glimmer's started calling me 'hun' and I am trying to think of one to call her, too!"

"Ohhh." I drag my nail between the two symbols, making an idle scratch. "So, that's nice, I guess. What's the big deal?"

"I think it's sweet, Bow." You pat him on the arm with a smack.

"It's *not* sweet. Well, I guess it is." He chuckles and rubs at the back of his neck. "Anyway I have to come up with one for her now and I'm stumped and it's bothering me."

"You could call her 'Sparkles.'" I shrug.

"No, I can't! That's *your* thing, Catra. And it sucks because that was a good one, too."

"Eh, whatever. I don't own it or anything."

"No, that's too weird. I can't take it like that. It's like…" He struggles for a second before gesturing emphatically at you, causing you to startle and drop the broom. "What if every time I saw Adora I started saying, ' *Hey, Adora* .'"

His voice cracks in the middle of the ‘hey’ and my ears flick in pain and lay back against my head. My claws instinctively drag over the crate I’m sitting on. “Don’t… don’t ever say that again.”

His fearful eyes stare back at me. Melog picks their head up from their lap to glance between us.

“Okay, we’re getting off subject.” You interject while picking up the broom again. You cradle your chin with your thumb and forefinger in thought. “What do people normally call each other? Other than their names, I guess.”

Bow sighs. “They’re called pet names, Adora.”

“You mean like how we called Swift Wind ‘Horsie’?”

“No, that was… I guess kind of? But they’re usually something endearing like sweetie or honey.”

“So why don’t you use one of those?” You pass the broom back and forth between your hands.

“Because they’re *terrible.* ” I start carving a line around the symbols I have been making, a circle for emphasis. “I wanna puke just thinking about hearing that every day.”

Melog mews in agreement.

“Hmmm, so maybe it’s stuff you eat then?” The gears turn in your head as you study Bow.

I bet Bow is doing a lot of… I quash that quip before it gets very far.

Bow’s shoulders slump. “Could be? But what do I use for that?”

“Uhm… what about those things she made for us when we ran from Prime into the asteroid field?”

My claw stops in the crate. A wash of emotions hit me and I feel them jam up in my heart. Relief, fear, regret… but mostly just the raw joy of seeing your face again shears through all of them. Melog stands and brushes along my leg and I release a breath I was subconsciously holding.

"Oh, they were like, dumplings or something."

"That sounds good! And it's something she made with her mom so maybe she'll like it?" You grin at him.

"Hmmm, that could work." Bow's expression relaxes as he finishes his consideration. "I like it. Now let's just hope she does."

A thought breezes through my mind. An ill feeling. "Bow, maybe you shouldn't—"

A puff of purple glitter snaps into the room in the midst of us. "Hey, guys!"

How does she always know where we are to teleport to us? "Hey, Sparkles." I lean back, and look down at my handiwork. When I see what I had been carving I drop my hand over it.

"You guys almost done in here?" She spins to you and Bow.

"Yup!" Bow gestures his enthusiasm across his chest with a closed fist. "Ship shape and ready for Entrapta to move her new parts for Darla in."

Glimmer peers around them. "It still looks like there's a lot of boxes in the way?"

You jump up with a blush on your face. "Uhh, right! Sorry. We were a little distracted. And *someone* hasn't been much help."

I wave you off, realize I used the same hand meant to cover my drawing, and quickly slap it back down.

"Well, I'll let Entrapta know it's still going to be a bit then. Don't keep her waiting too long. I think she wants off this planet soon."

"We'll get right on it." Bow nods, repeating his enthusiastic gesture from before.

"All right. See you soon, hun." Glimmer leans in and kisses him on the cheek.

"I… I look forward to it…" The words fall out of his mouth like an agonizingly slow disaster unfolding. He swallows. "Dumpling."

Glimmer's phase out of the cargo bay stops mid-transition. She snaps back into focus and the world hangs in a dreadful silence. I press my lips together trying to hide my grin. Melog curls up at my feet as small as possible, waiting for the lethal explosion of glitter.

"What did you call me?" Her voice is colder than a peak in the Kingdom of Snows.

"I… Dumpling?" His voice cracks again like glass.

She glares daggers at him. "Are you calling me that because I am *short* and *round* ?" Her words bite in a fury. An ominous glow builds in her hand.

I just hope she has the sense to keep us out of the collateral damage from the incoming spell. I tense on the crate, ready to leap away. I knew first hand what one of Glimmer's blasts could do.

You grip the broom tightly as though it's a staff, alarmed stare flicking between Glimmer and Bow.

Bow's eyes are wider than Etherian moons. He can only squeak in fear.

A laughter fills the cold void of Bow's imminent demise. It's coming from her. She buckles forward and braces herself with a

hand on his shoulder. Her laughs are a sweetness that rolls the fear away from around us.

Bow's starts laughing, cautiously. As though miming her will save his life. You join him as well. Melog and I hold still, the execution could still be imminent.

She leans up finally and wipes a tear from her eye. "Oh, I had you going, didn't I?"

Bow laughs nervously. "Yeah, you really did. You're not mad?" He covers the back of his neck with his hand.

She smiles at him. "Of course not. It's a really sweet thought, hun." She leans in again, and kisses his cheek once more. "Just think of a *different* one." Her hushed voice speaks louder than her anger did before.

Bow squeaks again and Glimmer poofs out of the cargo bay in a flash. He collapses into a seat and a slump against the nearby box.

Now I can't stop laughing. I put my hand over my stomach and loose a rattling joyous noise. I buckle forward. A weight is lifted out of my heart. I feel tears. I finally sit up. Bow is unchanged, save for now holding his head in his hands. But I see you.

I see your smile.

It feels good.

"Maybe we should… give you a minute, Bow." You lean the broom against the nearest crate and walk towards me.

He makes a noise of meager acknowledgment. Melog pads over quietly to sit next to him in support, resting their chin on his slumped shoulders.

When you reach me, you hold out a hand and lift me from the box. I am obligated to follow and stand up. Your face looms close

to mine before you look to the side where I was sitting, down at my idle works with my claws.

A & C.

You touch the symbols. “You’re still not much of an artist.”

“Oh, bite me. I do better than you.”

You grin, and lead me out of the room.

Bow will be fine.

Light

Chapter Summary

> I glide my hands over your back. How many scars do you carry because of me? I feel a dam cracking in my chest. “I hate it.”
>
> “Hate what, Catra?” You’re not bothered by my words.
>
> “You’re still Adora. Same jacket, same ponytail, same canvas pants. You’re the woman I remember. But then you’re She-Ra. You can just be another person. You became a princess but you…” You didn’t have to see, to do the things that I did.
>
> “Hey, hey, hey.” Your fingers cup the sides of my head, thumbs on my cheeks. You gingerly rest your forehead against mine. “She-Ra has nothing to do with what changed.” I feel you take a deep breath that wafts against my face. “But a lot did. Can I… tell you about it?”
>
> My eyes snap open. I pull away slowly to look up at you. Your soft face and sad eyes betray the weight you carry—I see you in the Heart of Etheria. When you accepted the unthinkable. “Okay.”

I sit on the cot. The stiff springs squeak in mild protest. My tail drapes behind me. Melog has already curled up at the foot of the bed. Cloaking the ship for so long must have really drained them.

You unfasten your belt and drop the red jacket off your shoulders. “Well, that went well.” You open our makeshift wardrobe and hang the jacket inside, delicately touching the fabric, straightening it carefully as you step away. What is that look on your face? Regret? Longing?

“I don’t know. I thought for sure Bow was about to get splattered across the cargo bay.”

"Not that." You snort a quiet laugh. "I meant getting the techy stuff for Darla." Your thermal shirt's golden hems glint in the simulated blue nighttime of Etheria.

"Ah, I guess."

"C'mon. Lighten up, Catra. We broke in, found the stuff, and got back out. A textbook mission." You smile at me from over your shoulder as you untie your ponytail. Blonde hair drapes down the back of your neck. Waves of blue from the lights in our room ripple through it like a sunset over the ocean.

"We did all right." I smile. Self consciously I comb my fingers through my shorn hair. I wanted it like this, but yours never changed. You've worn it the same way for as long as I can remember. "Entrapta seems to have bounced back once we got those components she was after."

"Yeah what was with that? I hope she's okay." You grasp the waist of your shirt and lift. Eight red lines stand out brighter than the others over your taut muscles. They stretch and twist as you fold the shirt away with its mates in the drawer. Those scars blemish you and they're not without company. "You and Glimmer get along all right?"

"Yeah, it was fine." I unfasten the buttons down the front of my shirt until I pause. I briefly fondle the golden wings of Bright Moon that adorn it before I continue. The loose fabric rolls off my shoulders and I chuck it aside. Echoes of thoughts from a fight long past sneak into my mind. They rend through my attempts at calm. Bright Moon. Sneering at you, taunting She-Ra. I scratch absently at my arm. "Do you think it would've been different?" Do you think we would've been happy? I try to bury the thought.

"What?" You stop and turn to me, night shirt hanging limp in hand. I glance at the center of your chest. Even when it isn't glowing, the Failsafe is a permanent brand on your flesh.

"If you never found the sword."

A nervous laugh breaks from you. “Where’s this coming from?”

“I’ve…” I fixate on your face. “You always feel the same, Adora. When I saw you… after Prime… you still looked the same.” Like the person I loved. “I just wonder some nights if you—we would’ve been happy in the Fright Zone if nothing ever changed.”

The uneasy humor strips from your expression. A seriousness overtakes you. In a blink, it is gone and you grin. “We wouldn’t have been this happy.” You walk towards me, stepping lightly on the bare plates.

“How do you know that?”

Something in my face compels you closer. You straddle my lap on your knees, fingers brushing across my cheek. “Things had to change.” You’re soothing and delicate in voice and touch.

I glide my hands over your back. How many scars do you carry because of me? I feel a dam cracking in my chest. “I hate it.”

“Hate what, Catra?” You’re not bothered by my words.

“You’re still Adora. Same jacket, same ponytail, same canvas pants. You’re the woman I remember. But then you’re She-Ra. You can just *be* another person. You became a princess but you…” You didn’t have to see, to do the things that I did.

“Hey, hey, hey.” Your fingers cup the sides of my head, thumbs on my cheeks. You gingerly rest your forehead against mine. “She-Ra has nothing to do with what changed.” I feel you take a deep breath that wafts against my face. “But a lot did. Can I… tell you about it?”

My eyes snap open. I pull away slowly to look up at you. Your soft face and sad eyes betray the weight you carry—I see you in the Heart of Etheria. When you accepted the unthinkable. “Okay.”

You lay down on your side tugging me with you. We face each other. Arms out, fingers intertwined between us. Your pale,

sapphire blue eyes shimmer in the low light.

"When I found the sword—" When you left. "—at first I thought She-Ra changed everything. I don't think we ever talked about that. I… We were fighting at the time. So it's hard to think about most days."

"Tell me about it." I feel a little pang that my sarcasm may ruin the intimacy. But your smile assuages the thought. I reach a hand out and caress your side, running my fingers along the naked skin of your waist. I stand strong against the onslaught of guilt rising inside of me.

"I met Light Hope right after. I don't think I told you much about her… them? Anyway, I had a new purpose. Light Hope convinced me of a destiny that She-Ra had. She was the program that guided Mara and tried to use She-Ra to activate the Heart of Etheria. To wipe out some threat long dead. Of course, she didn't say that. I just had a destiny. I had no choice in it. I had to *complete my training* ."

The resentment in that tone endears you to me and I relax a little.

"I wanted it though. I wanted that sense of purpose. And I always liked training." A sad smile crosses your lips.

"You? Nooo. Never." I grin back. The bubbling shame loses its grip on me.

"You know why, right?"

My thumb strokes your side over the scar from the Heart; even your wounds are silken smooth. How are you so strong, but so delicate? I meet your gaze. "Why?"

"We were weapons our whole lives. Everything about us—everything they did to us—was not to be people, but be trained to kill. Ever since we were kids." You reach up to brush my cheek with your thumb. Your eyes glisten. "When I first became She-Ra,

I had the best weapon I could ever ask for. I was powerful. Nothing could stand in my way. I became everything that the Horde trained me to be. Things didn't get easier."

I nod. Your fingers lovingly caress down the fur of my face.

"When I got what I wanted, I thought that was it. Goal achieved. I am the ultimate weapon, ultimate destiny. Everything that was forced into us with our training was fulfilled. But I wasn't prepared for what happened next. Life didn't stop. The world didn't just say 'good job Adora. You saved Bright Moon. Now you can live happy ever after.'"

"Because of me." I look down again, through you.

Your hands reach forward and clasp around the base of my skull. Fingers over my scabs and scar. An instinct to slash at you rises inside of me. If anyone other than you was touching me there, I'd—

"Catra, *no* ." I meet your eyes. Sincerity bleeds through every detail in your face. How do you manage it? "Because of the Horde."

I nod dimly. The words are rejected. A whirlwind stands against them. Of course you're saying that. Why wouldn't you? You love me. You won't admit the hurt that I did to you. You want me to feel better and you can just blame something that doesn't exist anymore. We're going to keep up this dance until something pulls us apart again.

Against the maelstrom of agony, though, something takes hold. A bulwark of your words dig in despite the resistance. Some tiny part of me believes you. I won't look away from you. Not from those eyes.

"We were taught horrible things, Catra. I liked being She-Ra for a long time because I could just be a weapon again. But I realized Light Hope was no different than Shadow Weaver or Hordak. They all betrayed me—they *used* me. When I found out what I was

going to do—my destiny—I broke the sword because it would destroy the world—destroy everything. I did it because I would not give up on Etheria. Not on my friends, and that means all of you." You caress the sides of my neck with your thumbs.

"Sometimes I don't see how. Not after everything I… we did." Tension relaxes in my back.

You draw me in slowly. "I never gave up on Lonnie or Kyle or Rogelio. On you. They were using you, as much as they did me. I hoped every night that you'd see it. I knew you just needed the chance. The reason."

I'm helpless to resist against your strength. I tuck into the embrace. "I couldn't see it. I tried. I almost did. But you just left when you found She-Ra. Like it was easy."

There's a puff of laughter, deep inside of it you conceal bitterness. My ear twitches against your chest. "It didn't make it easy to leave. She-Ra is strong, but she wasn't the strength that I needed. Now Mara, she…" As the words trail away, I hear your filaments of pain thread through her name. "I thought I killed She-Ra. I guess I might have. But she came back to me. I like to think because I had to fight my worst battles as Adora, not her. But that's not it."

You reach under my shirt and stroke delicately at my back. Your fingers push the wrong way through my fur and then smooth it back down.

"Then what?" My chest rumbles with my purring between us.

"Queen Angella said something to me before she…" Your words are as fragile as cracked glass.

Her name. Glimmer. My fault. My guilt. I clench my teeth.

You swallow. "She said, 'Take care of each other.'" There's a break in your voice, and your composure threatens to collapse.

The purring stops. “Adora…”

You take a hand and cup it over the back of my head and draw me in deeper, quieting my words. The other at my back. You rally yourself.

“That’s why She-Ra came back. I needed her help to save my friends. To save us. That’s what finally changed. Strength is helping those that you love. I understood what Angella said. And that’s what changed with you.”

I hold my breath again, stifling my emotions and my protests.

“I’m not changing because I’m a princess, or I have some demigod behind me. I’m changing because I have to be better. That’s why I knew I had to find you again when you gave Glimmer back to us. All we have is each other. We have to fight to be together. And you’re here right now with me because you’re fighting, too. You’re just as strong as me, and that’s one of the *many* reasons why I love you.” You bend down and kiss my forehead.

I blink away tears and close my eyes against your kiss. Can I believe that? I run my fingers over the scar from the Heart again. The one that nearly took you from me. “Okay.” I utter in my smallest voice. Not even sure if you hear me.

“I’m here for you. When you’re ready to talk, I am here to listen and love you through it.”

We lay there for a long time. My neck starts to hurt, I reach up to grab a pillow and knock something to the floor. It lands with a loud clatter of metal on metal. I smile against your chest. “Why do you still sleep with a knife?”

“I can’t break all my training.” I can hear your goofy smile even if I can’t see it.

“Even though you have a girlfriend with claws.”

"Well if anyone attacks then they have two badass women with sharp objects to fight off."

"You're my favorite idiot." My words are muffled against your chest.

"What?"

"Nothing."

I pause, looking back in the room one last time. You are enshrined in blue light on the cot. Melog shows less restraint from before and has assumed my spot in the spoon. In between the two of you, the nodes and lines of the Failsafe blossom on your chest in a faint glow. The sound of their purring harmonizes with your peaceful slumber and I smile. I fix a wrinkle on the shoulder of my sleep shirt, and I shut the door. My feet pad softly on the floor once more.

I sneak my way back to the cockpit. Everyone has their patterns, and this was always the quiet time to slip away. I thumb open the door and peer inside. I see Entrapta silhouetted by the purple globe of Darla's projection. I silently curse that my prospective solitude is violated.

Her tendrils of hair snake to either side of her typing on different panels of the ship. A clatter of keys serenade the quiet cockpit. I hear the murmur of her voice, but I don't smell anyone else in the room. No heady tang of Arrow Boy or the tingle of Sparkles—she's alone. Save for the glowing purple orb in front of her face.

"I'm sorry. I really tried." She carries a forlorn pain in her tone.

I hear no response. I twitch my ears and curl them into the room, searching for Darla's voice. Still nothing. I wonder how they are talking.

"It's not the same, but this will be good, too. When we get the systems running, we can *really* see what you can do!" I hear the little joy in her voice again, and I feel more at ease. Privacy doesn't seem possible tonight. I consider turning back to the room, maybe elbowing my way between you and Melog. Something makes me pause, a memory of the dock of Seaworthy, her clutching her data terminal to her chest as she stepped off The Dragon's Daughter VII.

I look back into the cockpit.

"Hey, Entrapta," I call out.

"Oh, Catra! I thought you were just going to sneak away again." She turns. Her smile is devilish in the contrasting light.

"You knew I was here?"

"Darla knows! She knows *everything* that is going on inside of her." Entrapta spreads her arms out excitedly. "Like right now Bow and Glimmer are—"

"More than I want to know, Entrapta!" I hold up my hands in some meager effort to stop her.

"Talking." Her voice lands dry.

"Oh." I drop my gesture and relax.

"They were doing a *lot* more than that before, though."

I pinch the bridge of my nose. "Thanks. Can I just come inside?"

"Whyyyy?" She keeps a coy smile.

"Because." Because something is wrong. "I'd like to know more about what you and Darla are doing. If that's okay."

She waves me off with a coil of her hair. “We’re just installing her new subsystems and running diagnostics together. You can go back to bed.”

“Can I stay? That sounds interesting.”

“It does?” Her voice flips from skepticism to joy. “Well, come then! I can show you what we’re doing.”

She pats the floor next to her, and I walk in tentatively. She is less taciturn than when we left the ship graveyard, but she still feels muted from her normal self.

The consoles of the cockpit form a point that Entrapta sits in the middle of. The sharp angles and edges of the ship are more prominent here. The different displays and controls ripple with light that glints against the angular canopy over our heads. Behind her, empty space. Stars.

“Please excuse my indecency, Catra.” Darla’s normally static voice seems off. Some edge of vulnerability in her tone? The schematic of the whole ship hangs in a hologram projected into the middle of the room. I look at the projection of exploded diagrams of the systems. Wires, components, and structure are all laid bare. I look to Entrapta for some clue as to what the ship meant.

“She means she’s naked,” she whispers to me.

“Oh… Oh! I don’t mind, Darla.” I look pleadingly to Entrapta.

She nods. “Exactly! Don’t be ashamed of your body.” She pats the console with a coil of hair. Her toothy smile is infectious and I feel one on my face, too.

“What are we working on?”

“Well, we got quite a few subsystems to install from the donors we found. I’ve been plugging them in with Darla and seeing what connections are still needed. The nanotech engines are building

the conductive pathways to the different logic systems, but sometimes they're a little out of date and I need to help with the differential between what the old systems were and the scans that you and Glimmer took."

"I understood some of that." I really want to.

She sighs in exasperation. "We look at pict—ures that are—" Entrapta catches herself in her usual condescending tone explaining something. There's a lingering thought in her ruby eyes. She looks at me, really looks at me. Her eyes flit left, then back at me. "Can I show you?"

That was new. "Sure."

She pulls up the diagram of Darla and moves it with her hair. She manipulates it as if it were a real model occupying the empty space. She pinches at the spine of the ship and withdraws a rectangular component from the model. She spreads the fingers of hair apart from a pinch and the piece grows in size and detail.

"This is the portal engine that we pulled from a scrapped ship. It doesn't match the one that Darla has in her banks. Specifically, there's a connection here." With more manipulations, she zooms in to the side of the piece where a bunch of open-ended terminals have no home on a small box. "I've been reading the schematics of the First Ones ships we obtained, and this box seems like it is a Transitive Projection Map."

"What's that do?" I attempt to divine out something in the box that would clue it into that purpose, but I just need to take her word on it.

"Oh it's real simple! You see the warp core is a space-time distortion engine that creates a locality—" She pauses and visibly considers her words. She really is trying. "I mean a point that warps space. It creates a portal using *immense* energy that we then fly the ship through. This portal-space isn't like our own. It's flat… kinda. So the projection map is a computer that converts

our local matter-space coordinates into portal-space locations. We 'fly' through the portal-space, go to the location calculated by the Transitive Projection Map, and *BAM* we're in a whole new location in matter-space!" Her eyes are gleeful as they dissect me for understanding.

I stare at her. I take a deep breath when I realize that I have been holding it. She really does know how to suck the air of a room with her explanations.

Her expression slips into resignation. "Nevermind."

"No, I…" I blink twice and collect myself. "That made sense. So we use the drive to open up a hole in space, and the map plots our course through the other dimension?"

Her eyes shimmer and her face lights up again. "Exactly! It makes sense if you know what principles it's operating on! You need a way to map between the two spaces. Darla has one piece of it, and the portal engine has the other. I just had to look at the connections and ran an elimination based on what Darla could and could not identify. It was between being the projection map, and the power source. And those wires are *awful* tiny to be connected to a thulite crystal!" She smiles at me. I want to say she is self-satisfied, but she has every right to be.

"That's amazing."

"She really does know her way around me." Darla's voice again hints at something that I can't quite place.

"Aw, you just say that to all your mechanics don't you." Entrapta reaches down and pats the floor plate.

The gesture catches me in the thought from earlier back in the hangar. "Entrapta, why were you looking for other ships?"

She looks at me with a sudden stony expression and gestures back to the schematic. "We needed the parts."

“That’s not it. What upset you? Why were you looking for ships that were ‘alive’?”

Her reflex is fast. She reaches up and snatches her face-mask down. The stylized bug looks back at me with glowing blue eyes. She turns back to the schematic and starts typing on the keyboard.

Did I shut her down? Push too hard? “It’s okay. I want to understand.”

“There’s nothing to understand, Catra. We’re trying to keep Darla running. She needed more parts. And we have so much more to install.” Her voice feels so similar to Darla’s in contrast to her energy before.

I consider. I withhold myself. Questions swirl with what she missed back in the hangar. Why it upset her so much. I resign to watch her work instead. The Transitive Projection Map seems to have installed successfully, and a new set of signs sprawl in front of her replacing the schematic from before. She works wordlessly. Her hair gestures through swirls and topographies. Sometimes it looks like a map of Etheria with the mountains and rivers carved in three dimensions, but she turns it and it transforms into an entirely different picture, despite it somehow being the same from before. She’s absorbed once more in data and science, though she hasn’t dismissed me away.

“This is incredible! I’ve never seen a six dimension map!” The new puzzle consumes her attention. Her melancholy voice lifts in the consumption of new information.

There’s only so much knowledge I can take for one sleep addled night. I’ll wait to ask for clarification another time. Instead, I let her continue. She flits through different shapes, locations, turns them, and shifts them to the side. She is acclimating herself to the new data it seems. She works faster, and faster. Her fixation is invisible under her mask. I consider standing and heading back to my room. Her shout stops me.

Entrapta lifts her visor and looks at me, her eyes glitter with tears and joy. “I found her!”

“Who?” I scoot closer to her, trying to see if I can tell what she’s talking about from the diagrams but it’s all nonsense to me. “Is it another ship?”

She raises her arms and pigtails up in raucous joy. “No! I knew something was off from before. This is the piece I have been missing!”

“Entrapta, help. What piece?”

“Hordak’s Portal! We didn’t have a working map when he activated it because the equipment was damaged. I *knew* we were missing something. He only wanted to alert Prime. It was never meant to be an actual wormhole through portal space across the dimensional boundaries, just a transmission. That must be why I missed it. When it opened, it consumed and scattered particulate matter across subspace with no destination! That was why there was a portal storm. It never closed until She-Ra intervened and interrupted the matter transference resetting us back to the origination point. With *one* exception. Portal space is single string matter so anything originating from our subspace will be obvious.”

My heart stops. “Are you saying—”

My words are cut off as the tendrils of hair ensnare me pulling me uncomfortably close to her. “I found her, Catra.” She shrieks with joy.

Has she been working on this for this long? “You’re certain?”

“I’m always certain until the data proves otherwise.” She beams in the glory of a proven hypothesis. “I found Queen Angella!”

Dark

The shower of blinding light subsides and a green Portal follows in the wake. It hangs in front of us suspended in the framework of metal and wires that Entrapta finished just hours ago. Memories blossom. I feel the heavy metal lever in my hand. It stings. Everyone's countenance is cast in a green that illuminates their trepidation. A nonverbal jousting plays out between all of us. Who goes in?

Micah breaks the silence. "I'll go."

"Dad, no! What if you can't find your way back out?" Glimmer says. "I can't lose you."

"I'm the most powerful sorcerer on all of Etheria. If anyone can find your mother, it's me."

" *Second* most powerful sorcerer." I recognize your face, that one of indomitable will. I hate it when you look like this.

Glimmer smirks.

"She's my wife, you two. I can find her anywhere she is," Micah says.

"We don't know that. When I was in the Portal, Angella found me and She-Ra's sword. That has to mean that I can find her." You hold out your hand. The strands of light summon from the immaterial ether and She-Ra's sword materializes. "For the honor of Grayskull!" The room is cast in a prism of light that beats back the ill glow of the Portal. She-Ra's regalia of white and gold contrasts with the green swirling mass. The Portal's tear of reality flexes from the summoning.

Bow is unphased by the display. "Angella was trapped because of She-Ra, though. You might not be able to come back." His thoughtful tone is welcome relief to the agitation in the room.

She-Ra opens her mouth to argue, but Glimmer cuts her off. “He’s right. Adora, we can’t risk losing She-Ra again. She needs to bring magic back to the universe. This is my mother we’re talking about. We’re both bonded to the Moonstone. That has to count for something. Plus, I can just teleport out of there if things get too bad.” Glimmer smiles genuinely with her hands clasped behind her back. A thin veneer that covers her doubt and fear.

“You don’t have a better way to find her than She-Ra.” Bow considers. “We need another solution. Entrapta, is there a way to set up a tracker on my pad? You said she is made of a different kind of matter.”

“No. Tech and signals don’t survive the Portal space. Our only choice is to use magic. The Portal key is our best detection device since it was what locked her in stasis in the Portal space.” Entrapta gestures with a strand of her hair at the She-Ra sword.

“So we don’t have another option. Only She-Ra can conjure and hold the sword.” She-Ra nods, her aura glows bright, unaffected by the Portal’s light that encases the rest of us. She always looks the strongest of us.

“No.” I grab at her bicep.

“Catra—”

“No. Stop. Everyone stop! Do you remember what it was like in there?” I scan the room, the only sound is the cracking and pulsing of the Portal in front of us.

“Exactly. Everyone here except for me and Adora, and…” I glance back at Entrapta, and see the mask is drawn, obscuring her face. She doesn’t want to be dragged into this. “I don’t think everyone understands what happened in there.”

I step forward into the midst of them, away from She-Ra. Away from her light. Melog follows cautiously at my heels. They haven’t liked this idea since Entrapta and I came up with it last night.

Everyone in the room shares the veil of courage in the threat of the ominous unknown.

"The Portal, the…" I hesitate on the word. "Hordak's Portal was different. It wasn't meant to jump between reality, just to send a signal. Entrapta and I think it then collected reality around our thoughts. Worlds were built out of our ideas or memories, but only some of ours. I got to live in my—" A word sticks again. *Our.* I can't say it. "My Fright Zone. You all lived in Bright Moon."

"Right, the Evil Horde never existed." Glimmer nods.

"And whose dream was that?" I turn to her.

"What do you mean?" Glimmer struggles. Her eyes look at me, pleading for an answer.

"It was Angella's." Bow's tone is resigned.

"Right. We think that means we either made the world, or we were a part of someone else's. I don't know why. The only people that can reach her can't be someone who was a part of her image. They have to be their own." I study their reactions as I stand alone in the middle of them. Micah and Bow's faces say they understand. Glimmer looks into my eyes, and then away. She knows, too. I glance back at Entrapta. Her head is fixated down, busying with a small circuit box that is already running perfectly. Only one of us can do this.

She-Ra approaches me, the golden heels of her boot clicks on the ground. "So I have to go then! I saw all of the realities."

"You don't—No! *Listen* to me." My tail stiffens in frustration. I catch myself and relax. "You did, but it can't work like that. Not this time. You saw everyone's reality, and broke them. Something about you or She-Ra or I don't know what. We don't know what that will do to Angella. You can't go, Adora. This time," I pause, look deep into She-Ra's—no, your—aquamarine eyes, those ones that always looked so out of place in the Fright Zone, "you can't save her."

She backpedals. A painful gap opens between us. Words can still wound the mighty She-Ra it seems. “Catra. You don’t know what’s in there. Last time you were in there you… We—”

“Adora, let me do this. I can find her. You have to trust me.”

“How do you know?” Micah’s normally stern voice is weak. There’s a crack in it. Hope. Fear.

“Because, the Portal, it shows us things about who we are. It showed me who I am. Or… was.” I look to the ground to avoid their eyes, their judgment. “If Angella sees any of you, you’ll just become part of her world again. I remember,” I touch the back of my neck, “I remember building things in ‘my’ Fright Zone. I’m strong enough to build a reality to reach her.”

“How would I get you back though?” There is a fear in She-Ra’s voice, yours. I gaze upward to her pained expression. She is still you after all.

My stride is delicate and confident as I approach her. I place a hand on hers that envelopes the grip of her sword. It is so much larger than mine. So strong. So warm. “With this.”

“I don’t…”

“She’s right.” Entrapta’s voice is slightly muffled by her bug mask.

“How do you know that?” Bow says.

Entrapta raises her mask. “She-Ra’s sword is drawn to her across time and space. Magic envelopes and threads through all realities, portal, ours, and others. It will always come back to She-Ra.” Her words are burgeoned with excitement and she clenches both fists in anticipation.

“I can’t just let you go in there.” The fear in She-Ra’s words almost makes me reconsider. Almost.

"Entrapta and I have been working on a plan. She has the models. If I have the sword, it might be enough." I smirk. I thread my fingers through She-Ra's and grasp the handle. It tingles in my grip, and a shiver ramps up and down through my spine.

"But only Adora has held She-Ra's sword since it came back. What if it disappears and we lose you, too?" Glimmer's sincerity strikes a chord in me. I try not to falter.

"Not true. I have theoretical models showing that a tie to She-Ra might be enough to hold on to the sword and keep it in corporeal space." Entrapta speaks with cautious excitement.

"So I think…" I gently pull She-Ra's hands away from the sword, and wrap mine around it. The world hangs in silence. I pick it up, hefting the weight in my arms. It is an enigma in my hands. I feel as though I can swing it in a deft swat, but my entire body is needed to hold it upright. It's nothing like her old sword; in fact, it is unlike anything I held before.

"How—How did you do that?" She-Ra's flabbergasted visage is framed in her golden tiara.

"I stole your old sword a lot—I figure how hard could it be to steal this one?" I smirk.

She-Ra's confusion flickers into indignation. "You didn't steal it a lot. Just—"

"I'm kidding." I set the point of the sword down and rest my hand on the pommel. "I love you, idiot. If that's not the best bond to She-Ra, I don't know what is."

She stares at me, shocked. A red overtakes her golden radiance as her cheeks flush. You flit out of the towering shape of She-Ra and into yours again. You run forward and embrace me. I feel everyone collapse around me as arms and bodies envelope me; tears, touches, shivering, and warmth.

After a time that seems it would stretch into infinity, they all let go. All except for you. You pull tight, your grip making it hard for me to breathe. “Please don’t do anything stupid.” Your words are borne through gritted teeth.

“Don’t worry. You haven’t rubbed off on me that much.”

I feel a laugh, you pull back, and your hands cup at either side of my face. Your lips framed in tears fall upon mine. My back quakes, and I steady myself with hands behind you. One still grips the sword, the other your shoulder. I feel our pasts and futures rise and fall in our passions. Dark nights huddled together. Laughter in the bright sun. The stillness and quiet of space. They all roll between us. With regret, I break from your kiss.

From the corners of my eyes, I feel the stares of our Squad.

“If it makes you feel better.” I slip back. Your fingers linger on my jaw and taper away. “I’m not going alone.” I hold my free hand out, and Melog places their muzzle under it.

You break a teary smile at Melog. “Look after her.”

Melog mews back. I feel a wetness on the fur of my cheek.

“Catra.” Glimmer’s hand touches my forearm. I turn my head to her. Glittering eyes lock into my own in her determination. “Find her. Bring my mom back.”

“I’m not leaving without her. I’ll be back soon. I—” Another word hitches in my throat. I push through. “I love you guys, and I’m going to make this right. I promise.”

I catch your pale blue eyes one last time, and I heft the sword in my hand. I nod and turn to the swirling green Portal. I can’t hesitate any longer. I step forward, light consumes me.

And then Dark.

I feel a nuzzle at my face.

Wake up.

"No, not yet. It's still dark out."

Catra. Wake up. It's always going to be dark.

I wake. Melog's blue eyes stare, but that's all I see save for the barest light of their mane and tail. Everything else is pure black. Cold pricks at my body. Only one thing keeps it at bay. I unfurl from my entanglement with the sword, my only warmth.

I stand. I'm not sure how. I have no orientation except for Melog's eyes. My feet are resting on nothing. There's no up, down, or anything in any direction. I see my body illuminated in the light of She-Ra's sword. It is the only other brightness in this dark.

Holding it closer to Melog, it lights up their body. Their mane and tail are barely visible. I point the makeshift torch in every direction around us, but nothing resolves in the void.

It wasn't this dark last time. I remember falling into the light. I remember pain. I remember light so bright it tasted like copper. My nerves fried with the electricity borne in the Portal. Each of them set on fire. Everything hurt. My body was unmade by it, piece by piece, each in agony as it was pulled away and blown away by the tumult.

Now the pain is gone. It's just dark.

I look down at Melog. "Where do you think we should start?"

An inquisitive mew.

"What makes you think I knew?"

Judgmental cry.

"No, I had a plan."

Another mew.

"It's way better than their plans! I had a model!"

Exasperated meow.

"Okay, enough. If you don't have an idea, let's just start walking."

I flex the grip of She-Ra's sword in my hand. I don't dare let it go. I don't know if holding onto it is necessary to keep it here with me, but I'm not going to chance it. There's no echoing of our feet in the dark. It consumes everything, even the light around us. It feels hungry. The landscape of nothing might be able to devour the very idea of us.

Cool, you found the Infinite Darkness room. The memory of you drags a smirk onto my lips. I head onward.

My steps grow longer, and more tired. My legs begin to ache as though I have been walking uphill, through molasses. Every step feels heavy. I pause to take a labored breath.

Melog stops to turn to me and chirrs.

"I just need to rest."

Concerned meow.

"No, it's fine."

Another meow.

"Would you *stop?* I knew what I was doing. This has to work."

Melog stops and bumps their head into me. The movement almost catches me off balance.

"Hey, watch it!" I stumble, driving the point of the sword into the nothing to catch myself.

Chirr, meow, chirrup.

"What?"

Another chirrup.

"How will that work?"

A softer push with their head.

"All right, all right." They're usually right about these things.

I grasp the handle of She-Ra's sword in both hands, and hold it point down. I fall to my knees, resting the point of the blade in front of me. Melog and the sword disappear as I close my eyes. It's truly black now.

Deep breaths. I think of Perfuma's face. Her smile. *Breathe in. Let the positive energy in. Hold. Let the light fill your dark. Hold. Breathe out. Push the negative away and out with your breath.*

I repeat. I don't know for how long, before her visage fades from my mind's eye.

Breathe in.

Glimmer and Bow curled up together with his lute.

Breathe out.

The tingle of the shock-stick as Entrapta falls lifeless in front of me.

Breathe in.

Melog chasing Sea Hawk across Salineas.

Breathe out.

The sea gate falling to the cannons of our navy.

Breathe in.

Scorpia smiling at me in the Crimson Wastes.

Breathe out.

Double Trouble telling me they betrayed me at the forge.

Breathe in.

You and me running through the Fright Zone as kids.

Breathe out.

She-Ra glaring at me in front of the broken Portal.

Breathe in.

Tackling you in Bright Moon, giggling, and kissing you. I feel grass tickling at my legs. Birds chirp in the distance. I hear conversation around us. Jovial calls, laughing, sounds like I have never heard before. The world is enveloped in calm. The wind caresses through my shorn hair, carrying a gentle perfume of flowers. Our new home.

I open my eyes.

Shadowed grass replaces the void. The glowing sword illuminates a circle of it that I kneel in. I can't make out much beyond that. Melog sits in front of me expectantly.

Mew.

"Thanks." I smile back at them.

I hold the sword aloft in my left hand and the radius grows. Just in the distance I can see some dark trees, but it all looks to be forest around me. No stars, no buildings, just more blackness outside of our dim light.

“Well, we’ve gone from wandering in nothing, to wandering in a dark forest. I suppose that’s an upgrade.”

The ghostly shapes of mushrooms sit like an expectant audience. While the trees loom and threaten to trap me in their embrace. There’s no noise. No scurrying creatures to betray any life in the forest. I get an Adora idea. I hold the sword out, perpendicular to the ground with both arms. I turn. After a full circle there was a slight difference to my left. I spin back, more slowly this time, and I feel a gentle tug, drawing me in that direction.

“Maybe that means something?”

Chirp.

“C’mon. Let’s go see.”

Hands reach out of the darkness every time the light of She-Ra’s sword touches them. They’re just trees, I tell myself. They look scary. But they’re nothing. They're definitely not the Carnivorous Princess Trees that the cadets talked about that live the Whispering Woods. I’ve been to the Whispering Wood. There’s nothing like that there… unless Perfuma conjured them up as a new trap for advancing Horde—No. I’m not in the Horde anymore. Those days are gone.

I take a slow breath in and hold it until my anxiety relaxes. Melog stays close to me, their hackles are raised in red translucent flame.

“It’s okay. They’re just—”

They snarl.

I look up in time to see a shape dash between the trees, just out of sight. I jump back with a yelp, tail poofing into a bottlebrush.

Melog positions themselves between me and the shadow. I grasp tightly at the sword with both hands.

"Stay away!" I hold it across my body defensively.

There's no movement, only stillness. Melog's growl is the only noise to fill the space between us. The sword is diminishing in incandescence. It weighs on me. Like a bucket being filled with water, it keeps dropping down, lower and lower as my strength wanes.

I see the figure move again. It dashes to my left. I turn, pivoting on the balls of my feet. I keep the sword up, between me and whatever darkness lurks out there. I remember to breathe. I grasp tightly at the panic in my mind. My claws bite into my palms as I grip the sword's handle.

The light returns, growing out from the blade. It pushes the darkness back, revealing the shadow.

"Who are you?" I try to be brave. I try so hard.

The shape moves towards me.

His body is an amalgamation of smoke and substance. Each step carries a puff of blackness that curls away from him. His four eyes glare at me, not the sickly green, but opaque milky white.

Horde Prime.

I stare at him. Steeling my resolve.

"You're not real."

He tilts his head back in a vile smile. An arrogant word is about to fall from his honeyed affect, until his shape fades. The only concrete bits of his form shift and fade slightly.

The shape coalesces into Hordak. He matches the broken wretch I knew so long ago. His body is so frail, ready to shatter

with another strike from my fists. But now he menaces me. His paces do not slow. I step back and regain my strength.

"Stop!"

The form shifts again. Panic nibbles at the back of my mind. It shifts into a mask adorning a cloud of shadow—Shadow Weaver's mask. There are no more steps, just a wafting tide of dark. It writhes, and the clouded void approaches me faster. I want to run, but I can't. Not anymore.

Melog cries out. The snakes of void reach around them.

"No!" I swing the sword in their direction, casting them in light. The smoke curls away like fog in sunlight. The void snakes turn back to me. Before I can move, they grasp around my legs, creeping up my body. They drag me towards the effigy of Shadow Weaver. I scream. I panic.

"Oh, Catra." I feel the utterance more than I hear it. Prime, Hordak, Shadow Weaver, all of their voices intermingle in a roar that bears down on me. My chest hurts.

I try to pick up the sword between us. It's so heavy.

The ghost of Shadow Weaver reaches a hand towards the mask. She grasps at it and lifts it in a slow agony that stretches between us. My face. Not a mirror, but one cast in dark except for the white incandescent eyes. It sneers at me, stretching the shadows over the visage longer and deeper.

"You belong here."

The tendrils grasp harder. I feel them pulling me down, away from the forest. I grip tighter on the sword.

"No." I grit my teeth.

"You were born in the shadow. You will live here."

“No!”

“We can’t deny who we are.” The words resonate in all voices of the shadows that haunt me.

Maybe… Are they right? I want to sit down. I want to rest. Borne of the shadows, raised in the dark. Broken. Never to be whole again. I am broken. I am pain. Shattered glass that other people walk on. I did this. I am here because I belong here. I—

The sword slips free from my hands, and I fall into darkness.

Forgiven

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It's moonrise.

The russet moon hangs above and casts the menagerie of machinery in its light. It reflects off the green, turning the whole world into a drab yellow. This was always your favorite time to be up here. In fact, you'll be here any second now. You were right behind me.

I wait in anticipation for your gasp. It never gets old. That same wonderment, you big dummy. I envy it some days, but just being around it is enough most of the time. I hear the *clink* of your grappling hook behind me.

Grunts from your struggle up the rope finally crest the platform behind me.

"Hey, Adora." I smirk.

But silence answers.

I turn. There is no grappling hook. Your face never crests that platform. I never see you.

That's right… you left.

I stand on that platform for weeks, months… years. You never came back, did you? You left me.

"Of course she left you, Catra."

I stiffen. Only one person spoke like that.

Shadow Weaver manifests in front of me on the platform.

"Why would Adora *ever* come back to such a miserable failure as you?"

"She's coming back. I just have to find her." I swallow.

"How long will you hold out hope? How long before you realize you are not enough to come back for?" She slinks towards me, and a shiver rattles up my body.

"That's… I guess you're right."

"Of course I am." The chill of her mask creeps closer to me. It rolls down the back of my neck. "There is only one path, one choice for you. You must follow in my footsteps. I have been preparing you for this, for the harshness of the world."

I nod. "T—Thank you, Shadow Weaver."

"We are only valued as long as we are useful, and Adora no longer has any use for *you* ." Her hands grasp my shoulders.

I stare out into the space where you once were. Where you always came up behind me. I knew every time I was on this platform that you would find me, hiding from the world. But it's not that way anymore.

"Then… what do I do?" I hold my hands out in front of me, looking at my palms. The darkness collects around them, and I recognize these hands, that of Shadow Weaver's.

"It's simple, really. Embrace the world's rejection. It will fuel you, and it will keep you safe."

I blink. "I've driven everyone away. Just like you told me." I feel their menace, their faces of hatred through the flames of my destruction. It is safer this way.

There's a flash, a shear in reality. I'm in the same location, but the moon has set. Darkness envelops the Fright Zone. Shadow Weaver is gone, but I'm not alone. You're here. You're standing in

front of me. No, I'm kneeling before you on the platform of the Fright Zone.

Shadow Weaver's voice rises up in my throat. I speak to you the only truth that I know. "You all hate me."

I never hated you.

There's another flash. The platform, the Fight Zone, collapses like a curtain around me. I am back in the dark, I am entangled coils of it. They writhe around me. Her face, her mask, it stares at me. I won't give up.

I collide soundlessly into a chasm. We're in the Crystal Castle, standing adjacent to the oblivion that was beneath us. On that narrow ledge, in that moment. Your hand reaches towards me.

Catra, wait… I'm sorry for leaving. I couldn't go back to the Fright Zone, not after I saw what the Horde was really doing.

Shadows slink towards us trying to tear apart. They reach for you.

"No." I hear my voice. Steel resonates in my soul. The percussion of my heartbeat pounds in my ears. I force my arms outward. Thick molasses of dark tries to hold me. I break free. Inch by inch. I reach out. Towards you.

I never wanted to leave you.

My hand stretches open before me, driving away the darkness, revealing the mask of Shadow Weaver, my tormentor. My demon. She surges at me, trying to push me back into despair.

...You could come with me!

I will.

I push back. The Crystal Castle falls away like shattered glass revealing a pure white canvas of nothingness. The consuming

luminescence of the Portal burns my eyes. In it, a lone figure. Myself. Twisted with hatred and shadow. She sneers in madness as she approaches me. She will consume me.

Thump-thump . It's not just my heartbeat. It's ours. In my open hand, threads of light collect, somehow brighter than the Portal around me. They coalesce together. Piece by piece, She-Ra's sword materializes. I grasp the handle, and the runestone shines radiant blue, pushing the light and the pain away.

"I started this!" My hands wring around the handle of She-Ra's sword. Its brilliance swirls and warmth burns away the despair in my being. She-Ra's—no, *your* power envelopes me. The shadow of myself hesitates. "I started this and I can make this right!" I step forward towards the apparition. "You… you can't stop me. Not anymore."

With all of my strength, I lift the sword up. "I don't *need* you anymore!" I cast the blade down, in a diagonal arc in front of my body. Raw prismatic light sweeps across the shadow being. There is a scream, an explosion of dark, and it's gone.

The light goes out, and I am in the shadowed forest again.

Melog cries in surprise next to me.

I blink away the tears in my eyes and look to them. They sit expectantly and mew at me.

"Thanks. I—" My thoughts are lost. Behind Melog I see a clearing. Buildings.

Bright Moon.

I crest through the trees and among them is a shape. Sitting high on a pedestal is the Moonstone. Shattered. The debris scatters up, suspended in the sky. Only the bottom half remains. The pieces look black, but a veneer of blue covers their surfaces.

It directs a ghastly light over the landscape. Everything is cast in a perverted shadow. Bright Moon is broken.

The buildings have gaping holes in them. The pedestal is crippled in the middle and threatens to topple. The bridge is shattered. It looks like…

It's Bright Moon, but the one I nearly conquered that day so long ago. The damage I caused, and the destruction lays bare before me. The palace is cracked, one of the wings of the spire has broken away and crashed into the ceiling. The domed living quarters next to it each show scars of battle. One has collapsed completely, the others have holes and show signs of fires that have long since gone out.

I shiver. There's a flash as I remember She-Ra's anger at me on that day. I feel Melog rub against my legs again and the image fades. The world turns back to shadow.

My grip tightens on the sword as I hold it across the front of my body. I nod and step into the shadow of Bright Moon. Silence reigns on my approach. The spires tower over me with every step, reaching impossibly high into the void. More thoughts, more ideas of that day menace at the back of my mind. I look back down, and Melog has not broken stride next to me.

I'm not doing this alone. I look at the sword. You're here with me, too.

I traverse the halls. Those that aren't shattered from the cannons sit in decay. Books are strewn about, their pages burned at the fringe and the words lost from wet rot. Collapsed benches and torn pillows dot the ruins.

I peer in the dark, and cast against a destroyed door is a skeleton clad in the Moon Guard's spaulders and cloak. I blink and it's gone. I shiver. My bare feet pad in the hall echoing among the desolation. I work my way up to the spire. I know where she is going to be.

I ascend the ruins of the palace that opens to the vista of Bright Moon, consumed in growing shadows. A gap of the shattered bridge separates me and the Moonstone. At my approach, the fragments all draw together and form a patchwork span with the rubble. It looks ready to give way at the slightest jostle. I step tentatively on a broken piece. Despite the condition, it holds firmly. I walk forward and each step unsettles gravel that falls away into the pit of nothing below. I spare a glance to the side; now just darkness sprawls below me. I steal a glance back, even the palace has been consumed by the void again. My focus resolves around my destination. Nothing else matters.

The Moonstone hangs atop the pedestal. It's whole now. Another flash, a memory, a cannon shot at the stone. This time it is not knocked away. It hits. The stone shatters. Did I succeed? Is this the world cast into the dark? Did I… Did I stop you?

Crack.

The bridge yields and I am only halfway. Melog screams at the ceaseless night.

"Run!"

I hold the sword tightly in one hand and with the other I scramble. I grab at falling stones and push with both legs. I frantically leap from fragment to fragment. Each step pushes against a weightless boulder, but I somehow manage to dig in every time. I feel myself losing ground, though. I dig my claws into the next one.

I can't fall. Who knows if I can ever find this again. My next grab fails. I reach out and find empty air. I freefall.

It's too far. The depths of woe call to me below and I scramble for anything to pull me back towards the runestone. Somebody… Anything… Glimmer's face intervenes in my terror.

A flash.

I land hard on stone with the sword clamoring in my grip. There is a familiar queasy feeling in my stomach. I turn. She isn't there. How did she…

"Thanks, Sparkles." I smirk.

Melog mews in pain next to me.

I sit up and reach out towards them. "Are you okay?"

There's another mew.

"Yeah, I know. I didn't pick the landing spot."

A cackling meow.

"I don't know. But knowing her, she probably snuck in."

Melog turns from me and towards the center of the platform we find ourselves on. I follow their eyes to the scene of woe. The Broken Moonstone hangs high in front of me, surrounded by the torch-like fixture. Under it, cast in the shadowy blue light, are the twisted wings of an angel.

My chest tightens, and I struggle for my next breath. I stand, slowly. The point of the sword inelegantly scrapes against the stone.

My feet move of their own accord, pulling me to the dark Moon Stone and the body that lays there. It is clothed in a torn dress, pale purple hair disheveled.

"Angella?"

The body shifts, rustling the debris.

"Queen Angella, is that you?" I step cautiously.

The pile shifts, and she sits up with a startle. I feel a reflexive hiss as I leap back a few paces. She responds by clamoring backwards.

"Who… who are you?" Her words stammer out.

"I'm sorry. I didn't mean to frighten you." Melog follows me as I approach her again. "I'm… I'm a friend of your daughter."

"Glimmer? Is she all right?" Her face slackens and is no longer fearful.

I get close enough to see her. My hand curls around my mouth. Her sunken eyes are black. They scan around blindly. Her cheekbones jut out on her taut face. Her bones, her body is emaciated more than anyone I have ever seen, even in the Fright Zone. She sits there like a pile of dust ready to be carried away in a breeze.

"I—Yes, everything is fine. She wanted me to find you for dinner."

"Is it dinner time already? The cooks did not ask me what to prepare."

"Yes, they, ah, well we didn't want to bother you. You were so busy with the Moonstone."

"Oh, well thank you. I must have lost track of time." She looks to the side, blankly.

"It's all right. What have you been working on?" I hold the sword aloft to see her better. Her eyes track the blade somehow even in her blindness.

"The Moonstone. It's been quiet. I have been trying to figure out why."

Its scattered fragments reach into the void of heavens over us. "I'm sure you'll figure it out."

"I'm trying. It has been so dark. I am afraid that Bright Moon may fall to the Horde if we cannot restore the Moonstone's power."

I step in closer. I need a reason to be here. Something. Melog bounds ahead of me and sits next to Angella. They rub their shoulder into her. “Oh my! Well, hello there.” She reaches up to pet at Melog’s head. I hear the purring from here. “Who might you be?”

An excuse like that will work just fine. Being telepathically linked to a magical creature has its benefits. “Their name is Melog. I brought them here to meet you.”

“They feel so different! I have not touched something quite of this nature before. They’re alive, but somehow in a different way.”

I lean on her good mood. “Oh, this is why I came to Bright Moon. Magic is opening up in the universe again. We found Melog on our… travels. They’re a pure magic being.”

There’s another affectionate rub. “That’s wonderful! Maybe with their magic the Moonstone will recover.” She smiles sweetly at me.

Pain, guilt drifts through my heart as I feel myself recoil away from her ghastly face. I swallow the fear and step forward again.

“It will. Adora, Bow, and Glimmer have done so much to help people all over. They want to tell you about it. I’ll take you to them to show you.” I extend a hand.

Her face sours a little. “No. I need to keep with the Moonstone. My duty.” She takes a shaky breath. “My duty is to protect it. I cannot leave it behind.”

I drop my hand. “You can, Angella. Things are getting better. But they need to get better on their own.” I walk closer and squat in front of her. I keep the sword between us, handle pointed towards her.

“That may be, but I must stay at my station. My daughter has her father’s spirit. She will bring the light of magic to everyone while I keep everything in order here.”

“Angella. I really want you to come with me.” I take a gamble. It should work. “King Micah is alive. Adora and Bow—”

“No, Micah's dead. My husband…” Her face turns dark in spite of the light.

“He isn't. He is waiting for you.” Tears cloud my eyes.

“He cannot be.”

“He is! Angella, he is. Please, come with me.”

“Stop with this nonsense. You are being cruel. My husband died long ago fighting when I would not.” I see snakes of clouded void crawl up behind her. Fingers of shadow. They are grasping at the edges of the pedestal we stand on. Melog bounds away from Angella as she grows in anger.

“Angella, he has been trapped on Beast Island. We found him. Just come with me, and I'll show you.”

“No. No no no!” Her words fall in wounded fury. “Why do you lie? Guards! Take her! We have a Horde soldier loose.” I feel a shake below us.

It can’t be over. Not this fast. The void creeps along the floor, snaking its way to us. I don’t know what it will bring, but I feel the space, the depths creeping in. Her guilt and despair can swallow me, too. I turn. I begin to step away looking at She-Ra’s sword grasped tightly in my hands. I can fight my darkness, but I doubt my ability to fight both of ours.

Melog chirrs, standing in front of me.

I pause.

I promised.

“Queen Angella, listen to me.” I approach and kneel at her.

“Begone! I don't want to hurt you!” Her hand is outstretched pointed at my face. It is a threat of a magic that would have ended me years ago, but nothing happens.

“This is all wrong. I need to bring you back.”

“What?”

“This is all because of me. You’re trapped, and your world is broken because of what I did. I… I’m so sorry.”

“How could you have done this?” Her sunken face stares blindly in disbelief.

“I… I wanted to rip the whole world apart. Everyone left me and I had nothing, and… I had to destroy everything they had. I was wrong and selfish and I don’t want to be that way anymore.” I clench my hands around the sword to hide their shaking. “I need to bring you back. I need to make it up to them, and you. Bow, Glimmer, Adora—they all found a way to love me even after what I did, but I don’t deserve it. Not until I make up for who I was and what I did.”

She looks at me incredulously. “Why do you say that?”

“Because I trapped you here. I need to fix it, I—”

“No, dear. Why do you not deserve their love and forgiveness?”

“Because I am awful and broken, and you’re stuck here because of me. You can’t leave because of what I did.”

“I don’t know who you are or what terrible things have happened, but you are a fool.”

I wipe a streaming tear from the fur of my cheek. “What?”

“You’re speaking nonsense. If they love you, you have done everything to deserve it. I would expect nothing less of my daughter.”

I sniff deep and bark out a laugh between sobs. “That does sound like Glimmer.”

“My daughter is strong. Her friends have made her stronger. They will only accept those that have earned their place in their lives. I promise you, you have earned their forgiveness, whether or not you realize it.” She smiles sweetly at me. “If my daughter has forgiven you, then I will find a way as well.” She-Ra’s runestone glows brighter, and it seems to fill in the sunken cheeks.

But a shadow lapses over her face. Figures stand all around us. They are the haunting shadows of Micah and the princesses. They loom. The snakes of void crawl closer, and I see one brush at her hand. The moment we share seems forgotten. Her countenance relaxes, and she looks around with mild confusion. “Hello, I don’t believe we have met.”

It’s getting worse. “I—I am a friend of your daughter. She told me I’d find you here.”

“My daughter?” She looks puzzled.

With the heel of my palm I wipe away another tear. “Yeah, Glimmer sent me to ask you for something.”

“Who is Glimmer?”

I set my jaw. I grip tighter at the handle of the sword. This darkness will pass. I will bring the light. “Glimmer is your daughter.”

“My daughter? I do not recall.”

“You can, Angella. Listen to me. Glimmer, she needs you. She needs your love again.”

“No, I must repair the Moonstone.”

I grab her shoulder with my hand and stare deeply into her eyes made of obsidian. “No, Angella. You don’t.”

“You cannot take me from my station. The Horde will take Bright Moon if I cannot repair the Moonstone.”

“The Horde is gone, Queen Angella. We need you now. Glimmer needs you.” She-Ra’s runestone pushes back against the darkness falling around us. Melog looses a frightened cry.

“I…”

“Think Angella. Fight. Look for the light. Look inside. Be the strength that you have inside of you, the mother… and the Queen.”

“I—My Glimmer is hurting, isn’t she?”

I nod. “Yes, and we can help her.”

“What do I need to do?” Her face sets in resolve, crawling past the blackness. I see her eyes returning, focusing on me. I push my will deeper into the sword. The darkness feels like a growing pressure threatening to collapse on us. But I am strong. We are strong.

“She wants you to look at She-Ra’s sword. They found a new one.”

“Wherever did she find that?” Her face alights in surprise. The sunken features beam in the radiance of the sword.

“It came to Adora when she embraced what you said to her. It’s a very long story. Right now, I just need you to hold it with me.”

“O—Okay.” She reaches out with a bony hand. I feel Melog curl behind me.

“It can channel our thoughts and feelings across the cosmos if we touch it. And our most loved ones will always be able to find

it.” I push the pommel towards her, and she grasps it tightly.

“We just have to think of them. Think of Glimmer. Think of where you—where we belong. And it will take us there.”

I close my eyes. From the darkness, a tide of light and warmth rushes at me.

You’re smiling. I can see all of Bright Moon behind you. Warm sun, bright grass, the moons high overhead. The palace glitters. Now whole. Angella is by my side, holding your sword with me. We step forward.

Into the Light.

The world reassembles itself. Darla’s cargo bay resolves like grains of sand falling from an infinite beyond. They’re all standing there. They were waiting for us.

I pick you out first. A concerned, anxious look adorns your face. You don’t wear it too well. When the last pieces assemble themselves, Darla’s artificial gravity clamps down on my body, and I stagger forward, away from the Portal. Your sword falls, clattering onto the floorplates.

I realize that the weight isn’t just my own. Angella has landed on me into a slump that I support with shaking legs.

There’s a collective gasp around the room.

“Angie!” Micah scrambles forward, practically tripping over himself. He grasps under her waist and pulls her off me. “Angie, oh my sweet Angie.” He falls, kneeling, cradling her like it was her last dying breaths.

“Micah?” Her voice is thin, weak.

He brushes a wayward strand of her hair away from her face. “Yes… Yes my love. It’s me.”

A flash materializes adjacent to Micah. “Mom!” Glimmer cradles the back of Angella’s head.

“Glimmer. Oh, oh Glimmer. I saw… I almost lost…”

“Shhh, save your strength.” Micah holds her closer to him.

“It’s okay Mom. You’re safe now.” She strokes the top of her mother’s head.

There’s a hand under my arm, it lifts me up, back onto my unsteady legs. “Hey, what’s—”

Your embrace squeezes the rest of my words out in a wheeze. There’s no words, just your face buried into my neck.

I reach around and pat at your back. I choke for words. “Adora, I’m going to—”

“Sorry!” You step back and I almost fall to my knees again. “Sorry, sorry! I just—”

“Hey.” I suck in a few breaths and steady myself. The swimming black spots fade away. “It’s okay. I missed you—” I inhale again. “I missed you, too.” I open my arms and coax you forward. “A little gentler this time.”

You rush forward again with tear stained cheeks. “I was so scared.”

There’s a mew next to us and Melog brushes against your leg.

“I told you I had help. Some of it unexpected.” I bury my face into your shoulder. That stupid red jacket. I don’t know how it still smells like the smoke of the Fright Zone, the flowers of Bright Moon, and the tang of your exertion. But it smells like home.

You laugh through your tears. “You know how bad Glimmer is at following plans.”

"Almost as bad as you." I smile and nuzzle my face deeper into your neck. "I would really… *really* like to lay down for a bit."

You jerk backwards. "Oh, right. Of course!" You take my hand and lead me out of the cargo bay.

I look to where the sword fell, only to see it has disappeared. Job finished, I suppose.

We get to the doorway before there is a tingling flash that tickles my nose with Glimmer's effervesce. I'm practically tackled into the wall. "Catra!" She's only slightly less constricting than Adora.

"Okay, *okay* . Someone's going to make me pass out here!" I feign a struggle.

"Just shut up and deal with it."

I relent and return the embrace. "Thanks for saving me back there, Sparkles."

"Someone had to look out for you." She plants a heavy kiss on my cheek.

I feel a burning flush in my face. "Hey, hey, hey! Getting a little affectionate here in front of my girlfriend."

Glimmer steps back, hands clasping mine. She brings them forward between us, pressing them together with her own. Her eyes swell with an earnestness that I've only seen in her a couple times. Earnestness and tears. "Thank you, Catra. Thank you so much. I'm never going to forget this."

The hotness in my cheeks doesn't subside. I have to look away. "I didn't… it was… nothing."

She breaks a teary smile. "It wasn't, but I'm not going to argue with you. I have my mom to look after."

You touch her shoulder. “I’ll take care of Catra. You go look after your family.”

Glimmer nods, and darts in for one more kiss on my cheek before she disappears in a burst of sparkles.

You grin, that stupid, lopsided, goofy grin of yours. Tension relaxes in my body, and fatigue rapidly sweeps behind.

“About that bed.”

“Certainly.” You take my hand.

I spare one last glance back. Glimmer, Bow, and Micah all huddled around Angella. As though afraid if they didn’t have their hands on her, she may disappear into the mists of the portal again.

There’s a tug, and I am pulled from my trance to follow you.

I lay still. My hands dare not move. There is quiet again. Real quiet. The world has melted away and there is warmth. You’re tucked under the crook of my arm, head nestled into my shoulder. The gentle droning of the ship intermingles with your deep breaths of slumber.

I stare up at the blue tinted ceiling. I can’t sleep, but I won’t move. I want this to last. There’s a familiar weight at our feet. Melog’s snore has a whistle to it. I never noticed that before.

You are nearly laying on top of me, arm sprawled across my chest, leg draped over mine. Normally your warmth is suffocating, but the cool air of the ship balances it out. I smile a little.

There’s a rustle. A sharp breath in, and you stir.

“Catra?” Your arm clenches around me.

“Hey, Adora.” I reach around with both arms and rub at your back, the gray tank top sliding against your delicate skin. The scars are small ridges underneath, muted hills of a pain that healed.

You relax, mumbling something. Your torpor disguises any sense of it.

“What?”

“Have you z’lept?”

“Not yet.”

“Mmm.” You awkwardly reach up pawing at my face. “Do you wanna get up?”

“No. I’m right where I need to be.” I touch your cheek with my thumb.

“Good. I wasn’t gonna let you up anyway.” Your face nuzzles deeper into my shoulder. Your errant hand reaches up, and with thumb and forefinger you clutch my ear rubbing softly.

Oh, oh that feels nice. My neck cranes in the direction of the touch. A resonant thrum of my purring joins the harmony of peace in our bed.

You keep with the ministration for a while, and I feel sleep catching up with me.

You stop. “I was so afraid you weren’t coming back.” Your voice is more lucid.

“I promised you I would.”

“I know. I just…” You take in a deep breath and then push up off me, sliding away. The departure of your warmth leaves me wanting, but I can see more of you now. Your pale blue eyes

capture the light of the Failsafe that hangs between us. “I wanted to go. I can’t lose you Catra, and I just had to wait.”

I roll over onto my side to face you. Our legs curl and knees touch. We both lay our hands between us and our fingers intertwine. “You dummy.”

“What did I do this time?” You smile at me. The Failsafe winks out and now the light of Darla plays off your figure, sculpting it with blue.

“Stop trying to fix everything for us. She-Ra, and especially Adora, are going to need help sometimes.”

Your smile lingers, and fades. You avert your eyes and nod. I watch you ponder through a question, looking as though you aren’t quite sure whether or not you want the answer. You look back up at me. “What happened in the Portal?”

I hear what is unsaid and I feel a ghostly tingle on the side of my face. “Well, I guess it was a big void. Not much was in there. Just whatever reality Angella and I made. It was…” I was scared. But I can’t say that. “Hard, but I wasn’t alone.”

Your hand releases mine, and it trails up slowly. With a tenderness borne from years of missed affection you tuck an errant strand of my hair up and away from the side of my face. “Did we help? Did I?”

“You did.” Your fingers elicit a small sigh from me as they wash away the ghost of our past. The fight that tore us apart, so we could be whole again in this moment together.

You close your eyes and shimmy in closer on your side. Our beings intertwine again and you rest your head on my shoulder, arm draped over me. “How?” Your voice is small, reminding me of the person I knew in the Fright Zone many lives ago.

“Well, I needed to find my way out of the dark a couple times. I thought of you. The rest was easy.”

The cot starts to shake. Your body spasms against me. I didn't think that would upset you that much. I look down to console you just to see your goofy grin on your lips. "Wow. If I didn't know any better, I'd think you like me."

"I do *not* ." I mock indignation and push, rolling you off me. Melog thuds off the end of the cot from the disturbance. I straddle your stomach and pin your shoulders back, biting at your neck. Gently.

"Help! I'm being attacked! A Horde soldier has snuck into my room!" you say through giggling, snorting laughter.

I sit up. My tail is flicking from side to side behind me. "Oh, is that help I hear you asking for?"

"Maybe." The Failsafe has faded, and the blue lights of Darla play over your mischievous grin.

I lean down. My face hovers over yours and your excited breaths thread through my fur. My lips are a feathery brush against yours. "I'll give you a hand then."

I fall into the kiss. Fingers luxuriate at the back of my scalp. Legs slide against one another. Bodies writhe and twist in an intimate dance. The world slips away around us. Our tides of passion carry away fear, fatigue, and doubt leaving only our naked souls intertwined.

You taste like love.

A mew interrupts us. I glance to the side where Melog sits looking indignant.

I sigh. "Fine, but I'm not getting up."

"Aw." Your voice thinly hides your disappointment.

Melog chirrs and hops up on the bed again at our feet.

“We can pick it up tomorrow night.” I shimmy down and rest my head on your chest. Fingers stroke down my back, lacing through my fur. My purring and your heartbeat are a percussive harmony. Silence lingers. Calm returns. Soon you are sleeping, and I feel my own rest overtaking me.

Nothing more needs to be said.

Chapter End Notes

Hello everyone! If you got this far to the end we would like to sincerely thank you for getting here. These are works of love and passion in a way that we felt was important to express. The writing style is very different from other things that we've both approached before, with a 1st/2nd person kind of writing, but it's been able to draw out a lot of emotions that are intrinsic to the show. It's a show about relationships, failure, and strength that people share together, and who exactly that 2nd person is has never mattered more than what we've seen in this series. We really appreciate the words of encouragement that we have gotten so far. It was our mission to capture the characters and their voices in as much detail in written prose as we can muster. It's difficult to write some of these walking disasters, but we're managing our best.

We've got a whole series of novellas incoming. This started as an initial passion project to get over writer's block and explore a character that was outside of my wheelhouse, and my friend and I wound up both getting so into it that every member of the BFS wound up with a voice, plus a couple adds.

Coming up next is Entrapta's story. Out of all the characters to express in 1st person, she has been by far my absolute darling. I've never encountered a character quite like her, and she wound up being an unmitigated joy to write & explore. I hope to see you there. ^_^ - DakianDelomast

* And if you're looking for anyone to blame, you can circle around to me. I binged She-Ra so hard and lured Dakian in. Next thing I know, I have a Catra novella thrown at me and not NEARLY enough Adora and I had to fix that. So... here we are. Each in charge of different character voices. Each trying to get the other one to cry -- 4theHonourofGrayskull



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